

NARUTO NEO UNIVERSE

A Novel of the Hidden Cloud



NANZO ARC

NARUTO NEO UNIVERSE

STORY OF ANITSU CLAN:

The Silence of Waves: The Anitsu Clan Massacre

A Naruto Neo Universe Past Arc

— WRITTEN BY —

NAVANEETH KRISHNA



NARUTO NEO UNIVERSE

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A Novel of the Hidden Cloud

Featuring

Nanzo Anitsu — The White Wolf

Pale skin · Wild black hair · Golden yellow eyes

Wave Style · Gravity Manipulation · Wind Style

Karui — The Stubborn Girl

From the original Naruto series

Red hair · Amber eyes · Kenjutsu master · Student of Killer B

WRITTEN BY

NAVANEETH KRISHNA

Based on the original Naruto created by

Masashi Kishimoto

NOWNET PRODUCTION

Complete Edition

NARUTO NEO UNIVERSE: NANZO ARC

Written by Navaneeth Krishna

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created by Masashi Kishimoto.

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remain the property of Masashi Kishimoto,
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Original characters (Nanzo Anitsu, Nora Anitsu,
the Anitsu Clan, and related story elements)
are original works by Navaneeth Krishna.

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Complete Edition — All Volumes & Chapters

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THE WAVERS OF KUMOGAKURE

A Naruto Neo Universe Novel

Story of Anitsu Clan: The Silence of Waves: The Anitsu Clan Massacre

A Naruto Neo Universe Past Arc

Year: 4 Years After the Third Great Ninja War

Location: Hidden Cloud Village - Anitsu Clan Compound

Casualties: 97% of the Anitsu Clan

Survivors: 4

Age of Nanzo Anitsu: 1 year old

The Secret War

The Uchiha Clan had always known about the Anitsu Clan.

While the rest of the shinobi world saw the Anitsus as merely another Kekkei Genkai clan with their mysterious Wave Style, the Uchiha—masters of the Sharingan and Genjutsu—recognized something far more dangerous: the Wave Style was the perfect counter to their visual prowess.

The Anitsu Clan's ability to manipulate vibrational waves extended to brain waves. Their techniques could disrupt the very chakra flow that Genjutsu required, shattering illusions before they could take hold. A master of Wave Style could literally vibrate their own neural pathways to break any Genjutsu, and at higher levels, could emit wave pulses that destabilized an opponent's chakra network—rendering even the Mangekyō Sharingan's most powerful illusions useless.

Fugaku Uchiha, leader of the Uchiha Clan and commander of the Konoha Military Police Force, had watched the Anitsu Clan

with growing concern throughout the Third Great Ninja War. While Konoha and Kumo were officially enemies on the battlefield, Fugaku understood that true clan security meant eliminating threats before they became problems.

The Wave Style represented an existential threat to Uchiha dominance. If knowledge of their counter- Genjutsu capabilities spread, or if the Anitsus ever allied fully with Konoha's enemies, the Uchiha's greatest weapon—their Sharingan—would be neutralized.

After the Third War ended in the Year of the Ten-Tails (the same year Minato Namikaze became the Fourth Hokage), Fugaku made his decision.

The Night of Broken Waves

It was called "Operation Silent Tide" by the Uchiha strike team—a covert assassination mission disguised as a rogue attack.

Fugaku selected twelve of the Uchiha Clan's most elite warriors, including three from the Military Police Force and four ANBU veterans. They moved under cover of a diplomatic mission to the Land of Lightning, officially there to negotiate post-war reparations. In reality, they carried black-market Kumo headbands and Lightning Release techniques—prepared to frame the attack as an internal Cloud Village power struggle.

Nayuta Anitsu, age 28, was the clan head and a master of Wave Style. He had fought in the Third War alongside the Fourth Raikage, earning the title "The Resonance Shield" for his ability to disrupt enemy Ninjutsu with precision wave pulses. His wife, Nyoko Anitsu, age 26, was the clan's chief medic and a genius at internal wave therapy—using vibrational healing that could mend shattered bones and purify poisoned blood.

They were young, powerful, and deeply in love.

They had a son—Nanzo—who had just turned one year old. He had his father's wild black hair and his mother's striking yellow eyes, the pure golden orbs that marked true Anitsu blood. He

was already showing signs of the clan's Kekkei Genkai, his baby giggles sometimes causing small ripples in the air around him.

The attack came at 3:00 AM, during the new moon when the Anitsu Clan's wave-sensitivity was at its lowest.

Fugaku himself led the strike.

The Massacre

The Anitsu compound was located on the eastern cliffs of Kumogakure, built into natural resonance chambers that amplified their Wave Style. The Uchiha struck the guard posts first—three Jonin-level Anitus eliminated before they could emit warning pulses.

Nayuta woke to the sound of his wife's scream.

He found Nyoko already in combat stance, their bedroom door shattered, three Uchiha standing in the doorway with Sharingan spinning. Nanzo was in his crib, wailing, his yellow eyes wide with terror.

"Uchiha," Nayuta snarled, his hands already forming seals. "You dare—"

"Wave Style is a threat to the natural order," Fugaku said, stepping from the shadows. His Mangekyō Sharingan—rare even among the Uchiha—glinted with deadly intent. "Your clan's ability to disrupt Genjutsu cannot be allowed to spread. This is not personal, Anitsu. This is survival."

The battle was catastrophic.

Nayuta unleashed the full power of his Wave Style, creating a Resonance Field that shattered the Uchiha's initial Genjutsu attempts. The air screamed as vibrational pulses tore through the compound, collapsing walls and rupturing the eardrums of two Uchiha strike members. Nyoko grabbed Nanzo and fled through a secret passage, her own Wave Style creating a Vibration Barrier that deflected a Fire Style: Great Fireball.

But Fugaku had prepared for this.

The Uchiha team had studied Anitsu Techniques for months. They knew the 15-minute cooldown between major Wave Style techniques. They knew the 5-meter blind spot where wave pulses couldn't reach without harming the user. They knew that Anitsu Clan members, for all their power, were vulnerable to physical speed in close quarters.

Fugaku activated his Mangekyō's special ability—"Kamunagi" (Divine Tool of the Gods)—a technique that allowed him to predict wave patterns by reading the subtle chakra fluctuations in the air. He could see Nayuta's attacks coming before they formed.

When Nayuta's first major technique—Wave Style: Internal Organ Rupture—killed four Uchiha instantly by liquefying their lungs, Fugaku simply wasn't there to be hit. He had already moved, closing the distance to the 5-meter dead zone.

"Your waves can't touch me here," Fugaku said, his voice cold as he drove a Chakra Blade through Nayuta's heart.

Nayuta died with his wife's name on his lips.

Nyoko's Last Stand

Nyoko ran through the secret tunnels beneath the compound, clutching Nanzo to her chest. Her son's terrified cries echoed off the stone walls. Behind her, she could hear the Uchiha pursuing—eight of them still alive, including their monstrous leader.

She reached the Emergency Resonance Chamber—a sealed room designed to protect the clan's children during attacks. Three other Anitsu children were already there, huddled with their mothers: Nora (age 8), Kiyoshi (age 12), and Mei (age 6).

"Nyoko-sama!" Nora cried, seeing the blood on her clan head's wife. "Where's Nayuta-sama?"

"Gone," Nyoko said, her voice breaking. She handed Nanzo to Nora—"Protect him. He's the last heir."

She turned to face the tunnel entrance.

"Nyoko-sama, no!" Kiyoshi grabbed her arm. "Come with us! The emergency exit—"

"The exit takes five minutes to open," Nyoko said softly, touching the boy's face. "They'll be here in thirty seconds. I can give you four minutes."

She kissed Nanzo's forehead. Her baby boy, who would never remember her face. Who would grow up an orphan, raised by the survivors in this room.

"Wave Style: Final Resonance," she whispered.

The technique was forbidden—Waver Mode's lesser cousin, a suicide technique that burned the user's life force to create a zone of absolute vibrational chaos. Nyoko's body began to glow with golden light as she poured every ounce of her chakra, her life, her love for her son into one final pulse.

The Uchiha burst into the chamber just as the wave released.

Fugaku's eyes widened. "Scatter!"

Too late.

The Final Resonance created a shockwave of pure vibrational force that tore through the tunnel system. Three Uchiha were instantly killed—their brains turned to jelly by the frequency. Two more lost their eyes as the Sharingan lenses in their sockets shattered. The remaining three, including Fugaku, were thrown back, their bodies broken, their chakra networks disrupted.

Nyoko Anitsu died standing, her body dissolving into golden particles of light, her final wave continuing to pulse through the compound for four full minutes—blocking all pursuit, protecting the escape route.

Her last thought was of Nanzo's smile.

The Rescue

The explosion of chakra—unique to the Anitsu Clan's Wave Style—alerted the entire Hidden Cloud Village.

A the Fourth Raikage was in his office when the sensors screamed. He recognized the signature immediately—Nyoko's

Final Resonance, a technique only used when the clan was facing extinction.

"Killer B! Darui! Cee!" he roared, already moving at lightning speed. "The Anitsu compound —NOW!"

They arrived to find smoke and death.

The Uchiha strike team—what remained of it—was trying to retreat through the eastern cliffs, carrying their dead and wounded. Fugaku, his right arm shattered by Nyoko's wave, was limping, his Mangekyō bleeding from overuse.

A the Fourth didn't hesitate.

"Lightning Style: Lariat!"

The blow caught the lead Uchiha—a Jonin named Teyaki—and snapped his neck instantly. Killer B was next, his Lightning Release: Double Lariat decapitating another. Darui's Black Lightning struck from the sky, turning two more Uchiha into charred corpses.

Fugaku faced the Raikage with seven dead clan members at his feet and his own body broken.

"This is an act of war, Uchiha," A growled, lightning crackling around his fists.

"Then let it be war," Fugaku spat, blood dripping from his mouth. "Your Wave Style users are dead, Raikage. We eliminated the threat. Whatever children survive will never reach their parents' potential— not without masters to teach them."

He activated a Space-Time Ninjutsu scroll—a forbidden technique stolen from the Nara clan archives —and vanished with the remaining two survivors, leaving his dead behind.

A wanted to pursue, but the cries of children stopped him.

In the Emergency Resonance Chamber, they found them: four survivors.

Nora (age 8), clutching baby Nanzo, her yellow eyes wide with trauma.

Kiyoshi (age 12), his arm broken, trying to be brave.

Mei (age 6), catatonic, rocking back and forth.

And Nanzo Anitsu (age 1), the clan heir, his golden eyes staring blankly at the blood on Nora's hands— his mother's blood.

Ninety-seven percent of the Anitsu Clan—over 200 men, women, and children—dead in one night.

The Aftermath

The Hidden Cloud Village went into lockdown. The Fourth Raikage wanted to declare war on Konoha, but the Kage Council intervened. Without proof that the attack was officially sanctioned by the Hokage —and with the Uchiha dead left behind wearing stolen Kumo headbands—the incident was buried as a "tragic internal accident" caused by "rogue elements."

Fugaku Uchiha returned to Konoha and reported the mission as a "preemptive strike against a hostile Kekkei Genkai threat." The Hokage and Council, wary of Cloud Village's growing power and unaware of the full scope of the massacre, officially reprimanded but secretly approved the elimination of a dangerous rival clan.

The truth was buried so deep that even most Uchiha didn't know of it.

Only Fugaku and the two survivors carried the secret—and the trauma.

The Survivors

Nora Anitsu, age 8, became Nanzo's primary caregiver. Too young to be a mother, but old enough to remember Nyoko's final sacrifice, she raised Nanzo with a fierce devotion that bordered on obsession. She taught him to control his Wave Style, to never show weakness, to hate the Uchiha with every fiber of his being.

She never told him the full truth—that his parents died protecting him, that his mother's last act was a suicide technique, that the Uchiha leader Fugaku personally murdered his father.

Not until he was old enough to understand the burden.

Kiyoshi Anitsu became a Jonin and the clan's military instructor, but he never recovered from the trauma. He died five years later during a routine mission—officially an accident, but those close to him knew it was suicide by combat.

Mei Anitsu never spoke again. She lived in the rebuilt compound as a caretaker, tending to the shrine of the dead, her mind permanently broken by the massacre.

And Nanzo?

He grew up knowing only that he was special, that he was the last heir, that he had to be perfect. He grew up with Nora's love and her hidden grief, with the weight of 200 dead on his tiny shoulders. He grew up learning Wave Style from the only teacher left, mastering Wind Style through sheer genius, developing his Gravity Manipulation through physics textbooks—because there were no other Anitsus to teach him the advanced techniques.

He grew up alone, the "Prince" of a dead clan, beautiful and white-skinned and yellow-eyed in a village of warriors, surrounded by the ghosts of his people.

Until Karui came.

Until she saw through the perfect exterior to the broken boy beneath.

Until she bit his neck and claimed him, not knowing that the scar she left mirrored the one Fugaku's blade left on his father's corpse—both marks of domination, one of death, one of love.

Legacy of the Massacre

The Anitsu Clan massacre remained one of the Hidden Cloud Village's darkest secrets. The Fourth Raikage kept the Uchiha

bodies in a sealed vault as evidence, waiting for the day when Kumogakure might need leverage against Konoha.

Nanzo learned the full truth on his 10th birthday—the same day the Second Great Ninja War began in the original timeline, but in this Waver Universe, the day Nora finally told him everything.

He didn't cry.

He went to the clan shrine and sat before his parents' memorial tablets for three days without eating or sleeping.

On the fourth day, he emerged with a new determination: he would rebuild the Anitsu Clan. He would master every technique his parents never had the chance to teach him. He would become so powerful that no one—Uchiha or otherwise—would ever threaten his people again.

And he would do it without Waver Mode, the technique that killed his mother.

Because Nanzo Anitsu understood , even at age 10, that suicide techniques were not power—they were surrender. And he refused to surrender.

Not to the Uchiha.

Not to fate.

Not to anyone.

10 years later In the Hidden Cloud Village, where Nanzo Anitsu was an aberration in the Hidden Cloud Village. A pale, beautiful boy with yellow eyes that seemed to glow in the dark, looked at with suspicion, envy, or pity by many.

At age ten, the mockery had already hardened into armor:

"Hey, prince! Lost your castle?"

The academy bullies would corner him during lunch. They never touched him. They knew better. Even at ten, Nanzo's Wave Style could rupture eardrums, could make their insides vibrate with nausea. But words were safe. Words they could use freely.

"Your parents died because they were too weak to protect you, white boy."

That one came from a Jonin instructor who had fought alongside Nayuta and Nyoko and resented their "precious" son surviving when better shinobi died. Nanzo said nothing. He went home and vomited blood from stress—Wave Style chakra eating at his own organs when his emotions ran too high.

"The Uchiha should have finished the job. At least Fugaku had the guts to kill your kind properly."

That was the worst. That was the one that kept him awake at night, staring at the ceiling of the rebuilt Anitsu Compound, listening to Nora toss in her sleep in the next room.

Nora—eighteen now, trying to be a mother to a boy who remembered his real parents' faces in nightmares. Nora, who had held him at age one while their clan burned, who had raised him on stories of Nayuta's strength and Nyoko's sacrifice.

Nora, who never told him the full truth about why the Uchiha came.

The White Minority's Whispers

Among some of the older pale-skinned clans in Kumogakure, Nanzo was simultaneously prized and pitied.

The elders of the few remaining pale-skinned clans would visit the Anitsu Compound, offering "condolences" that tasted like opportunity:

"Such a shame about your parents, young Nanzo. But perhaps... perhaps the Anitsu bloodline would be safer merged with our clan? Your yellow eyes are so pure. It would be a tragedy to see them diluted."

They wanted his genes. They wanted the Wave Style. They saw him as a resource—the last male heir of the only Kekkei Genkai clan in Cloud Village, beautiful and white and vulnerable.

"That dark maid who raises you—Nora, was it?—she's done her best, I'm sure. But a proper family, a proper white family, could give you so much more."

Nanzo learned to smile at these visitors. Learned to bow and thank them for their concern. Learned to activate his Wave Style just enough to make the air hum unpleasantly until they took the hint and left.

And then he would go to his room and scream into his pillow—screams that vibrated with chakra, that shattered glass, that brought Nora running with tears in her eyes.

"Why did they kill them?" he would demand, every night, as if the universe owed him an answer. "Why did Fugaku murder my parents? Why did the Uchiha hunt us?"

Nora would hold him and lie: "I don't know, Nanzo. I don't know."

She knew. She had always known. Shibai's whispers. The secret war. The threat of Wave Style to Genjutsu. But she was eighteen and broken and trying to protect the last piece of her family from becoming a monster of hatred.

So Nanzo grew up hating.

Not the village—he was too smart for that. The many in the village mocked him, but they also feared him. The some of the older clans coveted him, but they also needed him. No, his hatred had a specific, laser-focused target:

The Uchiha Clan.

Fugaku Uchiha, who had driven the blade through Nayuta's heart.

The strike team that had hunted his mother like an animal.

The Sharingan users who saw his clan as a threat to be exterminated.

He studied them obsessively. Learned their techniques, their history, their weaknesses. Planned—at age ten, he planned—how he would kill them when he was strong enough. How he would find Fugaku and make him feel Wave Style internal destruction. How he would eradicate the Uchiha the way they had eradicated the Anitsus.

It was the only thing that kept him going some days. The hatred. The promise of vengeance.

The News Arrives

It was a rainy Tuesday.

Nanzo was in the compound's small library—really just a room with salvaged scrolls—studying Wind Style theory when he felt it. A shift in the village's chakra atmosphere. Tension. Whispers. Running feet.

He walked to the window, yellow eyes narrowing.

A Jonin he recognized—Darui, young but already marked for greatness—was sprinting toward the Raikage's tower, his face pale. Behind him, other shinobi gathered in clusters, speaking in hushed, horrified tones.

Nanzo activated his Wave Style sensory technique—Pulse Reading—and felt it:

Shock. Disbelief. Fear.

Something had happened. Something big.

He found Nora in the kitchen, hands shaking as she prepared tea she wouldn't drink.

"Nora. What is it?"

She looked at him—really looked at him—and he saw something he didn't understand. Relief? Guilt? A terrible, complicated emotion that made her look younger and older at once?

"Nanzo... sit down."

"Tell me."

"Konoha. The Uchiha Clan." She swallowed. "They're... gone. All of them. Massacred. In one night."

The words didn't make sense. "Gone? What do you mean gone?"

"Dead. Murdered. By one of their own, they say. An Uchiha named Itachi. He killed them all—his parents, his family, his clan. Children. Elders. Everyone."

Nanzo stared at her.

His first thought was: Fugaku is dead.

His second thought was: I didn't kill him.

His third thought—the one that exploded through his chest like a Wave Style rupture—was: Someone else did my vengeance for me.

And then, rising through the shock like a bubble through deep water, came an emotion he didn't expect:

Joy.

Pure, terrible, relieving joy.

The Liberation

Nanzo didn't go to his room. He didn't scream. He didn't cry.

He walked out of the compound—past the gates, past the guards who called out to him, past the village streets where shinobi stared at the pale boy walking in the rain with a smile on his face.

He walked to the cliffs. The eastern cliffs, where his parents had died. Where the Uchiha strike team had cornered them. Where Nyoko had burned herself to ash to save him.

And there, in the rain, looking out at the endless clouds that gave Kumogakure its name, Nanzo Anitsu laughed.

It started as a chuckle. Then a giggle. Then full-throated, hysterical laughter that echoed off the rocks and made the birds scatter.

"Itachi!" he shouted to the storm. "ITACHI!"

He didn't know the name. Had never heard it before today. But he shouted it like a prayer.

"You did it! You killed them! You killed them ALL!"

He fell to his knees in the mud, still laughing, tears streaming down his pale face—tears of relief, not grief. For the first time in his conscious memory, the weight of hatred lifted. The burden of vengeance— of planning, of dreaming, of needing to kill—evaporated like mist.

Fugaku Uchiha was dead.

The strike team was dead.

The clan that had hunted his family, that had reduced his people from hundreds to four, was erased from existence.

And not by his hand. By one of their own.

"Thank you," Nanzo whispered to the rain, to the ghost of a boy he'd never met. "Thank you, Itachi."

The Respect

In the weeks that followed, Nanzo learned everything he could about Itachi Uchiha.

The information was fragmented—Konoha kept its secrets, and the massacre was a wound they covered with silence. But Kumogakure's intelligence network was thorough, and Nanzo had resources. He was the clan head, even at ten. People answered his questions.

He learned:

- Itachi was thirteen—only three years older than Nanzo. - Itachi was a prodigy—ANBU captain at age eleven, chūnin at ten, the greatest genius of his generation. - Itachi had spared one person—his younger brother, Sasuke, left alive to "hate him, to grow strong, to kill him."

Nanzo thought about that last part for a long time.

He thought about what it meant to kill your own family. To make that choice. To carry that weight. To be willing to be hated for the rest of your life, to let your only surviving relative grow up dreaming of your death, all for... what?

For peace, the whispers said. To prevent a coup. To stop a war. To protect the village from the Uchiha's planned insurrection.

Nanzo didn't believe that. Not entirely. No thirteen-year-old killed their entire family for abstract political stability. There had to be more. Deeper reasons. Darker truths.

But whatever the truth, one fact remained: Itachi had done what Nanzo could not. He had looked at his clan—the people who raised him, who shared his blood, his eyes, his techniques—and he had judged them worthy of extinction.

And he had acted.

"He's stronger than me," Nanzo told Nora one night, staring at the intelligence reports spread across the table.

Nora looked worried. "Nanzo... you can't admire him. He's a monster. A mass murderer."

"Yes," Nanzo agreed calmly. "And he's also the reason I can sleep at night."

He looked up at her, his yellow eyes—Nyoko's eyes—clear and steady.

"For ten years, I've dreamed of killing Fugaku. Of killing them all. It was the only thing that made the mockery bearable. The only thing that made being 'The White Ghost' survivable. I was going to become a monster to kill monsters."

He tapped the report with Itachi's face—a young, beautiful boy with Sharingan eyes that held depths Nanzo couldn't fathom.

"He did it for me. He carried the weight for me. He became the monster so I don't have to."

Nora was silent. She thought of Shibai's whispers. Of her own hatred, carefully hidden, for the Uchiha. Of how she had wanted to tell Nanzo the truth—that the Uchiha attacked because they feared Wave Style, because they were threatened, because they were desperate.

But looking at her boy—no, her young man, sitting there with the burden of vengeance finally lifted—she couldn't say it.

"What will you do now?" she asked instead. "Without the hatred?"

Nanzo smiled. It was a new smile—not the sharp, defensive baring of teeth he used against mockery, but something genuine. Something free.

"Grow strong," he said. "Not to kill. Not for revenge. Just... strong. Strong enough to protect what's left. Strong enough that no one ever needs to become Itachi again."

He looked out the window, toward the village that had mocked him, that had called him prince and ghost and weak.

"And maybe," he added softly, "strong enough to understand why he did it. To know the full truth. To thank him properly, someday."

End of Arc: The Silence of Waves

Next Arc: The Forest Battle - How Karui Defeated the Last Anitsu

VOLUME I: THE PRINCE AND THE STUBBORN GIRL

Chapter 1: The Weight of White

The morning sun rose over Kumogakure like a wound in the sky, bleeding gold across the lightning- charged clouds that perpetually gathered around the Hidden Cloud Village. Nanzo Anitsu stood on the balcony of the clan compound's eastern wing, his pale fingers gripping the stone railing with a tension that belied his calm expression.

He was twenty years old, and he had buried his parents ten years ago.

The Second Great Ninja War had taken them—his father, the previous clan head, struck down by Iwagakure's explosion corps; his mother, the clan's sealing master, dying three days later from wounds that no medical ninjutsu could heal. Ten years old. He'd been ten years old, standing in the ruins of what had once been a clan of sixty, now reduced to four survivors.

Four, including himself.

"Nanzo-sama." The voice came soft from behind him, carrying the particular cadence of someone who had raised him from childhood. "Your tea is getting cold."

He didn't turn immediately. Instead, he let his yellow eyes—those distinctive Anitsu Clan orbs that marked him as blood descendant—trace the village below. From this height, he could see the training grounds where shinobi moved through morning katas, their bodies silhouetted against the dawn. Nora sometimes spoke of purity and legacy in ways that made Nanzo uneasy.

"Nanzo-sama?" Nora repeated, closer now.

"Coming, Mom," he said, finally turning.

The word slipped out naturally in private, as it always did. Nora's face softened—that complex expression of love and grief and something else he couldn't name. She was forty-five now, her white skin beginning to show fine lines around eyes that matched his own. Yellow pure eye balls, the mark of their bloodline. She had been his father's cousin, unmarried when the war came, and afterward she had

simply... taken him. Raised him. Trained him in the Wave Style that threatened to destroy him from the inside out.

"Your formal robes," she said, setting the tea tray on the low table. "The Raikage has requested your presence at the summit meeting. Darui-sama wishes to discuss the border tensions with Iwa."

Nanzo moved to the table, settling into a kneeling position with the grace of someone who had been trained in propriety since birth. The Anitsu Clan might be nearly extinct, but they were still nobility within Kumogakure—the only Kekkei Genkai clan in a village that prized strength above all else. Their Wave Style, derived from secret Ōtsutsuki lineage that only the clan head knew, made them invaluable despite their numbers.

Or perhaps because of their numbers. Scarcity created value. Nanzo understood this intimately.

"Has there been word from the northern patrol?" he asked, accepting the tea with both hands—a gesture of respect that made Nora's eyes glisten.

"None since yesterday's report." She settled across from him, maintaining proper distance. In public, she would kneel behind him, the proper position for a maid. In private, they shared tea as family. "Omoi- san's team is due to return today. Perhaps they'll have intelligence."

Nanzo felt something tighten in his chest at the mention of Team Samui. Not because of Omoi, the worry-prone swordsman, or Samui herself with her cool efficiency. No, it was the third member of that team who made his chakra fluctuate dangerously, who made the Wave Style in his blood hum with an agitation that had nothing to do with combat.

Karui.

The stubborn girl from the many in the village.

He set down his tea with deliberate care, remembering too late that his fingers had been trembling. Nora noticed—she always noticed—but said nothing. Instead, she reached across the table and adjusted his collar with maternal precision, her touch lingering a fraction too long.

"You look tired," she said softly. "Did you sleep poorly?"

"I slept fine." The lie came easily. In truth, he had dreamed of red hair and amber eyes, of a voice shouting challenges that he couldn't answer, of gravity itself failing to hold something in place. He had dreamed of his own helplessness, and he had woken with his heart hammering against his ribs.

Nora's hand withdrew. She studied his face with an intensity that made him want to look away, to hide the things he wasn't saying. But he had been raised to be clan head, to be perfect, to be the Prince that everyone expected. So he met her gaze and let her see what he chose to show: duty, composure, the mask of the Anitsu heir.

"The summit is in two hours," she said finally. "I will prepare your formal attire. The white silk with the wave patterns—it emphasizes your lineage."

"Thank you, Mom."

She rose, bowed properly, and moved toward the door. At the threshold, she paused. "Nanzo?"

"Yes?"

"Be careful today. The Raikage's meetings... they take a toll." She didn't look back. "I worry about you. I have always worried."

He watched her go, the door sliding shut with a whisper, and wondered why her words felt like a warning rather than comfort.

The Raikage's chamber occupied the highest point of Kumogakure's central tower, accessible only by a series of guarded elevators and chakra-sealed stairways. Nanzo ascended alone, his formal robes—the white silk Nora had chosen—flowing behind him like water. The wave patterns embroidered in silver thread caught the light with each step, creating the illusion of movement, of power barely contained.

Two guards flanked the final doorway, their dark skin marking them as typical Kumogakure shinobi. They bowed deeply as he approached, showing the respect due to a clan head even one so young.

"Anitsu-sama," the left guard said. "Darui-sama is expecting you."

The door opened onto a circular chamber with windows on all sides, offering a panoramic view of the village and the mountains beyond. Darui, the Fifth Raikage, stood at the eastern window, his characteristic lazy posture belying the sharp intelligence in his eyes. He was like most of the village, his hair white with age and experience, the legendary Black Lightning crackling faintly around his fingertips.

"Nanzo," Darui said without turning. "You're early."

"I find punctuality prevents complications."

Darui laughed, a low rumble that seemed to vibrate through the floor. "Spoken like a true clan head. Come, look at this."

Nanzo moved to stand beside him, following his gaze to the training grounds far below. From this height, the shinobi looked

like insects, their movements precise and deadly even at a distance.

"Iwagakure has been testing our eastern border," Darui said. "Small incursions, nothing decisive. But persistent."

"Explosion Corps?"

"Some. But there's something else." Darui's fingers stopped their idle crackling. "They have a new weapon. Something that disrupts chakra networks—not sealing, exactly. More like... vibration. Frequency interference."

Nanzo felt ice form in his stomach. "Wave-based?"

"That's why I called you here." Darui finally turned to face him, his dark eyes serious. "Your clan's techniques are unique, Nanzo. If Iwa has developed something similar, even crude, it represents a significant threat. I need you to analyze what we've recovered."

He gestured, and a side door opened. A medic-nin entered carrying a sealed container, which she set on the central table before retreating. Nanzo approached it with the wariness of someone who had learned that beautiful things often contained deadly secrets.

Inside the container, nestled in protective foam, was a fragment of metal no larger than his palm. It looked ordinary—scorched, twisted, unremarkable. But when Nanzo extended his chakra senses toward it, he felt something that made his blood run cold.

Resonance.

The metal was vibrating at a frequency that matched, impossibly, the harmonic signature of Anitsu Clan Wave Style.

"This is..." He stopped, choosing his words carefully. "This is sophisticated. Beyond typical Iwa engineering."

"Can you counter it?"

Nanzo closed the container, sealing his chakra away from the disturbing resonance. "I need to study it properly. In my clan's laboratory, with our equipment. And I need time—at least a week."

"You have three days." Darui moved to his desk, retrieving a scroll. "There's more. One of our patrols intercepted a courier carrying this. It's coded, but the destination is clear."

He handed over the scroll. Nanzo unrolled it, his eyes scanning the characters that seemed to shift and blur on the page—a sophisticated cipher, but one that he recognized from his father's old records.

"It's addressed to someone in the village," he said slowly. "An agent. The code references 'the white prize' and 'the dark contamination.'"

Darui's expression didn't change, but the air around him grew heavy with suppressed Black Lightning. "The white prize. That's you, Nanzo. The last male heir of the Anitsu Clan's main line. And the dark contamination..."

"Karui," Nanzo finished, the name escaping before he could stop it.

"Your... friend." Darui's tone was carefully neutral. "The one who defeated you in that forest incident."

"She is not my friend." The denial came too quickly, too forcefully. "She is... she was an opponent. A training exercise."

"An exercise that left you with a permanent scar on your neck and her with a reputation as the woman who tamed the Anitsu Prince ." Darui's lips twitched, almost a smile. "The village talks, Nanzo. Even I hear the gossip."

Nanzo's hand rose unconsciously to his left neck, where beneath the high collar of his robes, he could feel the raised skin of Karui's bite mark. The scar that had never faded, that he touched in private moments with a complexity of emotion he refused to name.

"The scroll," he said, forcing his voice steady. "It suggests Iwa has an agent in Kumogakure who wants to eliminate me, or perhaps use me. The reference to Karui suggests they see her as... leverage. A way to control me, or to destabilize the clan."

"Or they simply want to remove what they perceive as a threat," Darui agreed. "A Anitsu Clan head with close ties to one

of Killer B's students represents a significant power bloc. If they can drive a wedge between you, or eliminate one of you..."

"They weaken the village's internal structure." Nanzo rerolled the scroll, his mind racing through possibilities. "I need to warn her. Karui. She's on patrol with her team, due to return today."

"I've already sent word. They'll be diverted to secure quarters upon arrival, debriefed separately." Darui's hand fell on Nanzo's shoulder, heavy with meaning. "But you should know—there are elements in the village who agree with Iwa's assessment. Who see your... connection to Karui as problematic. The some of the older clans is small, Nanzo, but vocal. And some of them have influence."

Nanzo thought of Nora, of her careful words and her love that felt increasingly like possession. "I am aware."

"Are you?" Darui's grip tightened slightly. "The Anitsu Clan has always been... insular. Pure, as they say. Your father married within the clan, as did his father before him. The idea of the clan head taking a wife from outside, particularly from the many in the village... it threatens certain people's sense of order."

"Karui is not my wife." The words tasted like ash.

"Not yet." Darui released him, moving back to the window. "But the village sees how you look at her. How she looks at you. And in times of tension, such things become weapons."

Nanzo stood silent, the scroll heavy in his hands, the metal fragment's resonance still echoing in his chakra senses. He thought of gravity locks and cooldown periods, of the five-meter dead zone where he was helpless, of red hair and a voice that had called him Prince even as teeth sank into his neck.

"I will handle it," he said finally. "The Iwa threat, the cipher, the internal politics. I am clan head, Darui- sama. I have been trained for this since I was ten years old."

"I know." Darui didn't turn around. "That's what worries me."

Chapter 2: Flashback

The Forest of Broken Pride

Timeline: 10 Years Before Present | NanzoAge 10-15

Part I: The Orphan Prince

The whispers started the day Nanzo entered the Academy.

“Look at him—white as a ghost.”

“Yellow eyes like a monster.”

“The Anitsu freak.”

Ten years old, clutching Nora’s hand, still raw from learning the truth about his parents’ massacre. Nanzo walked through the Academy gates with his chin high and his heart shattered.

The other children were dark. Kumogakure’s majority— of the population, the Raikage and Killer B and all the heroes he had heard about in Nora’s stories. They were beautiful in their darkness, powerful in their sameness.

And Nanzo was white. Pale. Yellow-eyed. The last of a dead clan, raised by a girl only two years older than him who was technically his maid but functioned as his mother.

“Don’t listen,” Nora whispered, her own white skin and yellow eyes marking her as his only kin. “You’re special. You’re rare.”

But rare meant target.

The Academy instructors were professional—mostly. But Nanzo saw the hesitation in their eyes when they graded his work. The way they flinched from his Wave Style demonstrations. The way they called on him only when necessary, as if his very existence was a reminder of some shameful secret.

The children were less subtle.

“Hey Prince,” Darui—then a genin, already tall and sharp-tongued—called out one day after class. He didn’t mean it cruelly, not really. Just... observationally. “You gonna cry if I bump you? That white skin looks soft.”

Nanzo didn’t cry.

He vibrated.

The Wave Style pulse was uncontrolled, raw, powered by grief and rage. It threw Darui back three meters and ruptured the water main in the courtyard.

Nanzo was suspended for three days.

The some of the older clans—the who clung to their “purity”—whispered that the “Prince was violent.” The many in the village decided the “Prince was dangerous.”

Both sides agreed: something was wrong with Nanzo Anitsu .

Part II: The Physics of Isolation

By age twelve, Nanzo had learned to weaponize his isolation.

If they called him Prince, he would be the most beautiful, most untouchable Prince in the village.

He grew his hair long and wild—black wolf hair, Nora called it, the traditional style of Anitsu Clan heads. He wore white silk instead of the practical dark colors of Kumogakure. He walked with perfect posture, chin elevated, yellow eyes looking down his nose at everyone.

“Good morning, commoners,” he would say, passing groups of students.

“My chakra reserves are beyond your comprehension. Please don’t speak to me unless you can calculate gravitational fields.”

He was intolerable. He was deliberately intolerable.

The mockery evolved:

“There goes the Prince.”

“Think his diaper needs changing?”

“Who’s gonna marry the white freak? He’s gonna die alone and rebuild his stupid clan by himself.”

“Unlucky.”

That word—unlucky—became his shadow.

Some used it with spite: “Unlucky to be born Anitsu. Unlucky to survive the massacre. Unlucky to be so pretty and so useless.”

Others used it with pity: “Unlucky kid. No parents. Raised by another kid. Acts like a Prince because he’s scared.”

Both were wrong.

Nanzo acted like a Prince because rage was safer than grief. Because if he was going to be alone, he would be alone on his own terms.

He threw himself into physics—the one subject where his white skin and yellow eyes didn’t matter. Where calculations were pure and gravity didn’t care about clan politics. He understood wave propagation, resonance frequencies, field theory. At fourteen, he was correcting Academy instructors on chakra dynamics.

“You’re smart,” Killer B told him once, after a private lesson on Wave Style control. The legendary jinchūriki was one of the few heroes who treated Nanzo as equal—perhaps because B understood what it meant to be feared for what you were. “But you’re also an asshole.”

“Thank you,” Nanzo said, perfectly composed.

“I’m serious, little prince. That attitude gonna get you killed. Or worse—it’s gonna make you kill someone who doesn’t deserve it.”

Nanzo didn’t listen.

He was fifteen, fully grown into his beauty, his power, his arrogance. The Wave Style was mastered. The Wind Style—dangerous, self-destructive, brilliant—was developing. He had begun sketching the first equations for Gravity Manipulation, though he wouldn’t complete it for years.

He was unstoppable.

And he was miserable.

Part III: The Dark Girl Who Didn’t Care

Karui was seventeen when she decided she wanted Nanzo Anitsu

Not because he was beautiful—though he was. Not because he was powerful—though he was. Not because he was the last heir of a legendary clan—though he was.

She wanted him because he looked at her like she was dirt, and she knew—knew with the certainty of Killer B’s training and her own stubborn heart—that he was lying.

“Ugly dark girl,” he called her, the first time they sparred. Academy demonstration, advanced students only. “Don’t touch me with your sweaty hands.”

“Prince,” she shot back, grinning, not offended at all. “You hit like a dying butterfly.”

He hated her immediately.

Hated that she wasn’t intimidated. Hated that she laughed at his insults. Hated that she was dark— beautifully, defiantly dark, with amber eyes that caught the light like honey—and that she clearly thought his white skin was weird, not wonderful.

“You’re disgusting,” he told her after she blocked his Wave Style pulse with sheer physical speed. “Dark and ugly and common.”

“And you’re soft,” she replied, bouncing on her toes. “All that pretty white skin and no real combat training. What happens when I get close, Prince?”

He panicked.

She saw it—the micro-expression, the flicker of yellow eyes toward his feet, the unconscious step backward.

He has no close combat ability, she realized. All that power, all that range, and he’s helpless up close.

She didn’t exploit it then. She was seventeen, he was fifteen, and despite his arrogance, there was something broken in his eyes that made her hesitate.

But she watched him.

Watched the other girls fawn over his beauty while he sneered at them. Watched the boys mock his “Prince” behavior while he pretended not to hear. Watched the some of the older clans gossip about how unlucky he was, how tragic, how wasted.

And she watched Nora—eighteen now, technically his maid, functionally his mother—hovering with desperate protectiveness, killing anyone who got too close with polite words and cold eyes.

“He needs someone to break him,” Karui told Omoi one night, drinking cheap sake in their shared apartment.

“He needs therapy,” Omoi said, ever practical.

“Same thing.”

At forest near the cloud village 1

The Hidden Cloud Village stood silent beneath a bruised purple sky, but in the ancient training grounds northwest of the village gates—where the trees grew so thick that sunlight barely touched the moss-covered earth—two storms were about to collide.

Karui of Kumogakure, age 17, Chūnin, kenjutsu specialist under Killer B himself, adjusted her forehead protector and tightened her grip on the long katana strapped to her back. Her amber eyes scanned the clearing with the practiced intensity of someone who'd grown up in a village where dark was the standard—where the Raikage himself shared her rich skin tone, where Killer B's darkness was legendary, where of the population looked like her.

She wasn't supposed to be here. None of the girls were. Not when he was training.

But Karui had never been good at following rules that didn't make sense.

Nanzo Anitsu, age 18, head of the nearly-extinct Anitsu Clan, moved through his kata with the kind of beauty that made people forget to breathe. White skin that seemed to glow in the forest dimness. Black wolf hair—wild, untamed, framing a face of almost painful elegance. And those eyes...

Yellow. Pure yellow. No whites, no pupils, just liquid gold that marked him as blood descendant of the only Kekkei Genkai clan in Cloud Village.

The rare white-skinned, yellow-eyed minority. The "Prince" that every girl in the village whispered about. The orphan who'd lost his parents at ten, raised by his clan's maid Nora, survivor of a clan reduced to four living members.

Karui watched from the treeline, amber eyes narrowed. She'd liked him once. From a distance. Like all the others. But Nanzo Anitsu didn't care about dark girls. He'd never looked twice at any of them—too

busy being beautiful, too busy being above the common majority that made Kumogakure strong.

White is ugly, she thought, the mantra she'd developed to armor her heart against his indifference. Dark is beautiful and sexy. Whites are disgusting. Except...

Except when he moved like that. When the wind itself seemed to bow to his will.

She stepped on a branch.

Crack.

Nanzo stopped mid-motion. Those golden eyes turned toward her, and Karui felt her stomach clench— not from fear, never from fear, but from the weight of being seen by someone who'd never truly seen her before.

"You're in my training ground," he said. His voice was cultured, distant. The voice of someone who'd been raised on grief and legacy and the weight of a dying clan. "Leave."

"Make me," Karui said, stepping into the clearing. Her hand rested on her sword hilt. "I've watched you, Anitsu. You think you're untouchable. Beyond-world-level, they say. Stronger than Kage. The last hope of your precious white bloodline."

Nanzo's perfect lips curved. Not a smile. A dismissal.

"You're that dark girl," he said. "The loud one. Killer B's student." He tilted his head, studying her like she was an insect. "Flat-chested, too. Omoi mentioned it."

The words hit like shuriken. Karui felt heat rise to her face—not shame, but rage. The same rage that had made her beat Naruto Uzumaki savagely when he'd refused to give up

Sasuke. The same rage that made her ESTJ Type 8 soul scream for dominance.

"Fight me," she demanded.

"I don't fight commoners."

"Fight me, or I'll tell the village the Anitsu Clan head is a coward."

Something shifted in those golden eyes. The mask cracked—just slightly—revealing the wounded boy beneath, the orphan who'd had to become a god to survive.

"Very well," Nanzo said softly. "But understand—this is not a spar. This is a lesson."

It began with wind.

Nanzo didn't move. He simply raised his hand, and the air between them screamed. Karui threw herself sideways as an invisible blade carved through the space she'd occupied, shredding bark from a century-old oak.

Wind Style: Massive Destroyer.

"Long range only," she gasped, rolling to her feet. Killer B's training had taught her to analyze fast, to find patterns in chaos. "You can't use that close-range without killing yourself."

Nanzo's smile widened. "Clever. But irrelevant."

He raised both hands.

Gravity Manipulation.

Karui felt it instantly—a crushing weight that slammed her to her knees, then flat against the earth. Her bones creaked. Her lungs seized. Every cell in her body screamed for relief as the artificial gravity he'd created—founded on his academy expertise in physics, refined through years of solitary study—pinned her like a specimen.

"Five-meter dead zone," she choked out, understanding even as her vision blurred. "You can't... affect anything... within five meters..."

"True." Nanzo walked slowly toward her, stopping just outside that invisible boundary. Six meters away. Safe. Untouchable.

"But you can't reach me, can you? Dark girl. Stubborn girl. Ugly girl."

He circled her, golden eyes cold with something that wasn't quite cruelty—was it loneliness? Desperation to prove his superiority to someone, anyone, after losing everything?

"Ugly weak daky," he murmured, and the words cut deeper than any blade. "That's what you are. What you'll always be. The many in the village—common, unremarkable, beneath notice. I'm the last of a bloodline that descends from gods. You? You're one of thousands. Dark like the dirt. Dark like—"

"Shut up."

Karui tried to rise. Failed. The gravity was absolute—no chakra could move, no muscle could contract against the force he'd calculated so precisely. She felt something tear in her shoulder, felt blood fill her mouth from where she'd bitten her tongue.

And then the waves came.

Wave Style.

Not through the air—through her. Vibrations that bypassed skin and muscle and struck directly at organs. Her lungs liquefied slightly with each pulse. Her heart stuttered. Neural pathways shattered and reformed wrong, sending signals of agony that had no source, no cure.

Death pain. Without external wound. Without warning.

"Your tenketsu are collapsing," Nanzo informed her, still circling, still six meters away. "In fifteen minutes, your chakra network will be permanently destroyed. You'll die as a civilian. A failure."

He was playing with her. She realized it through the haze of suffering—he could kill her instantly with a precise brain wave disruption, but he was drawing it out. Taunting her. Trying to break her spirit with humiliation because...

Because he's never been touched. Never been truly challenged. The some of the older clans Prince, surrounded by dark excellence he can't understand, clinging to his rarity as

superiority.

"Give up," he said softly. "Admit you're ugly. Admit you're weak. Admit you're dark—and that darkness will always be second to light. Say it, and I'll release you."

Karui's amber eyes—amber, not his pure yellow, beautiful in their humanity—met his golden gaze.

And she smiled. Bloody. Fierce. Stubborn.

"Tch."

She began to study him. Even as her organs screamed. Even as the gravity held her pinned like a butterfly to a board. Killer B's training: When you can't move, use your mind. When you can't fight, find the weakness.

Five-meter dead zone. He stayed at six meters—just outside it.

Wind Style: long and mid-range only. Vortex would absorb him at close range. Massive Destroyer would kill him too. Air Absorption had no effect within five meters.

Wave Style: on cooldown after use. Fifteen minutes between applications.

Gravity Manipulation: one minute duration... then thirty-minute cooldown.

He'd been talking for forty-five seconds. Showing off. Playing the beautiful, cruel prince.

Fifteen seconds left on the gravity lock. Wave Style already used and cooling. Wind Style unusable at close range. No taijutsu skill—he's never needed it. No kenjutsu—relies entirely on jutsu.

When the gravity releases... he'll have nothing. Nothing for thirty minutes. Nothing for fifteen minutes. Just his white skin and his pretty face and his emptiness.

"You're going to die," Nanzo said, but there was something uncertain in his voice now. She wasn't breaking. Wasn't crying. Wasn't begging.

She was smiling.

"Three," she whispered.

"What?"

"Two."

He stepped back. Instinctive. Afraid.

"One."

The gravity vanished.

Karui didn't hesitate. Didn't think. Exploded upward using the flash-speed movement Killer B had beaten into her through years of brutal training—closing six meters in less than a heartbeat, ignoring the death pain still ravaging her insides from Wave Style damage, ignoring the blood pouring from her nose and ears.

Nanzo's golden eyes went wide. He tried to raise his hand—
Wave Style on cooldown. Fifteen minutes.

He tried to push—

Gravity on cooldown. Thirty minutes.

He tried to summon wind—

Would kill them both at this range. Suicide.

For the first time in his life, Nanzo Anitsu was helpless.

Karui didn't use her sword. Too impersonal. Too clean.

She bit him.

Her teeth sank into the left side of his neck with all the fury of a girl who'd been called ugly dark one too many times, who'd watched the some of the older clans clutch their pearls while surrounded by dark excellence, who'd been rejected by a boy too beautiful to see her strength.

She bit until she tasted blood. Until her jaw ached. Until she felt the cartilage of his neck give slightly beneath her determination.

And she held on.

Nanzo made a sound—half scream, half something else, something broken and vulnerable that he'd never let anyone hear. His hands came up to push her away, but he had no strength—never trained for this, never imagined being touched, being marked, being claimed by someone he'd dismissed as

beneath him.

They fell together. Karui on top. Her teeth still in his neck. His golden eyes staring up at the canopy, shocked, tears streaming from the corners because no one had ever—

No one had ever—

"You," she growled against his bloody neck, finally releasing her bite but keeping him pinned with her weight, her dark skin against his white, her amber eyes burning into his yellow. "You with your 'ugly weak danky.' Your 'common.' Your 'beneath.'"

She grabbed his chin, forced him to look at her.

"I am Karui of Kumogakure. I am dark like the Raikage. Dark like Killer B. Dark like of this village that you think you're above. And I just defeated you—not with jutsu, not with bloodline, but with teeth and will and the stubbornness you mocked."

Nanzo stared at her. Bleeding. Marked. Hers.

His lips moved. No sound.

"I claimed you," she whispered, fierce and possessive. "This bite—" she touched the wound she'd left, already swelling, already permanent—"this is mine. You are mine. The some of the older clans can gossip about their 'Prince' being stolen by the 'ugly dark girl.' Let them. I am the majority. I am the standard. I am what this village looks like."

She leaned down, her dark lips close to his pale ear.

"And you? You're beautiful, Nanzo Anitsu. I'll give you that. But you're weak without your jutsu. Helpless. A Prince who needed a dark girl to teach him what real strength looks like."

She stood. Her body screamed from Wave Style damage—she'd need medical attention, would carry internal scars forever—but she stood tall. Dark. Proud.

"Thirty minutes," she said, looking down at him still sprawled on the moss, hand pressed to his bleeding neck. "That's how long your gravity is on cooldown. Fifteen for Wave Style. I'm going to walk away now. When you can move again, come find me."

She turned.

"Karui." His voice—broken, raw, changed.

She looked back.

Those golden eyes, which had been so cold, now held something like... wonder? Terror? Recognition?

"You... you didn't kill me."

"I don't kill helpless opponents," she said. "Even pretty white ones who call me ugly." She smiled, fierce and loving even then, even before the love was real. "Besides. I want you to remember this. Remember how a dark girl from the majority made you helpless. Remember my teeth in your neck every time you look in the mirror."

She walked into the trees. Didn't look back. Didn't see him touch the wound with trembling fingers, didn't see him realize that for the first time since his parents died, since Nora raised him alone, since he became a god to survive—

—he'd been seen. Truly seen. Darkness and all.

Aftermath:

The bite scar never faded. Nanzo wore it on the left side of his neck, a permanent crescent of teeth marks that he touched when he needed to remember.

Chapter 2: The Return

The secure quarters were located in the southern quadrant of the village, a series of rooms reserved for high-value debriefings and protective custody. Karui had been in them before—after the Five Kage Summit, when she had beaten Naruto Uzumaki bloody for information about Sasuke Uchiha, when her temper had made her a liability that needed containment.

She hated these rooms. The walls were too thick, the windows too small, the air too still. They reminded her of being trapped, of gravity holding her in place while a voice mocked her from beyond reach.

"Will you stop pacing?" Omoi asked from his position against the far wall. "You're making me nervous, and when I get nervous, I start thinking about worst-case scenarios, like what if this is actually a trap and we're being held here because someone discovered that time I accidentally—"

"Omoi." Samui's voice cut through his anxiety spiral with surgical precision. "Silence."

Karui shot her teammate a grateful look. Samui sat at the small table, her blonde hair catching the overhead light, her expression composed as she reviewed the mission report for the third time. They had returned from the northern patrol to find an escort waiting, orders to surrender their equipment, and instructions to wait in isolation.

Something was wrong.

"Three hours," Karui said, not stopping her pacing. "We've been here three hours. No debrief, no explanation, just—wait. This isn't standard procedure."

"It's political," Samui said without looking up. "The way they separated us from our gear, the specific location of these quarters—this is protective custody, not detention."

"Protective custody implies a threat." Omoi's hand drifted to where his sword would normally rest. "Who's threatening us?"

"Iwa," Karui said flatly. She had been thinking about it since they were intercepted, turning over possibilities in her mind. "The northern patrol found evidence of Explosion Corps activity near the border, but no actual engagement. Then we're pulled into isolation immediately upon return. Darui- sama is preparing for something."

"Preparing for what?"

The door opened before Karui could answer. She spun, hand reaching automatically for a sword that wasn't there, and found herself face to face with the one person she had not expected to see.

Nanzo Anitsu stood in the doorway, his white formal robes immaculate, his yellow eyes fixed on her with an intensity that

made her breath catch. He looked different than she remembered—older, somehow, though it had only been weeks since their last encounter. The lines around his eyes were tighter, his posture more rigid. The scar on his neck, her scar, was hidden by his collar, but she knew it was there. She always knew.

"Karui," he said, and her name in his mouth sounded like a confession.

"Prince," she replied, because old habits died hard, because she needed the distance that mockery provided.

Something flickered in his expression—pain, perhaps, or memory. Then he stepped into the room, and she saw that he wasn't alone. Two ANBU flanked him, their masks featureless, their presence a reminder that this was official business despite the intimacy of his gaze.

"Samui-san, Omoi-san," Nanzo said, his voice shifting to formal politeness. "The Raikage requests your presence in the tactical chamber. Your debrief will be conducted by Darui-sama personally."

Samui rose smoothly, gathering her reports. Omoi hesitated, looking between Karui and Nanzo with the sharp eyes of someone who missed nothing. "And Karui?"

"Remains here." Nanzo's tone brooked no argument. "I need to speak with her. Alone."

The ANBU didn't move. Karui felt her temper rising, that familiar heat that had always been her weakness and her strength. "Alone? With the clan head? That seems improper, doesn't it? A dark girl from the majority alone with the precious white prize of Kumogakure?"

"Karui." Nanzo's voice dropped, becoming something private, something that existed only between them. "Please."

She had never heard him say please before. Not when she had defeated him, not when she had marked him, not in all the complicated months of their association. It stopped her anger more effectively than any command could have.

Samui touched her shoulder as she passed—a brief pressure, comrade to comrade. Omoi's look was more complicated, worry and curiosity and something like warning. Then they were gone, the door sealing behind them, and Karui was alone with the man she had bitten, the man she had trained, the man she refused to call by name because names meant attachment and attachment meant vulnerability.

"You look terrible," she said, because kindness had never been her language.

"You look beautiful," he replied, and the simplicity of it shattered something in her chest.

"Don't." She turned away, moving to the window, putting physical distance between them. "Don't say things like that. Not here, not now. You called me here for a reason, Anitsu-sama. Political, according to Samui. So be political."

She heard him move, the whisper of silk against stone, and then he was behind her. Not touching—he never touched her without permission, not since the forest—but close enough that she could feel his presence like warmth against her back.

"Iwa has targeted you," he said, his voice low. "They see you as a way to get to me. Or as a threat to be eliminated to destabilize my position."

"Because I defeated you." It wasn't a question.

"Because you defeated me. Because the village sees us as... connected." He paused, and she heard him swallow. "Because I cannot stop looking at you, and everyone knows it, and that makes you valuable to my enemies and dangerous to my allies."

Karui turned to face him. He was closer than she expected, close enough to see the gold flecks in his yellow eyes, the faint shadow of exhaustion beneath them. Close enough to hurt him, if she wanted. Close enough to be hurt, if he chose.

"Your allies," she repeated. "The some of the older clans. The ones who call me the ugly dark stubborn girl who stole their Prince."

"Some of them, yes."

"And your mother? Nora-san?" She watched his face carefully, saw the micro-expression of pain that he couldn't quite hide. "Does she think I'm a threat too?"

Nanzo's hand rose, stopping just short of touching her cheek. She could feel the chakra in his fingers, the controlled vibration of Wave Style held in check. "Nora loves me," he said carefully. "She wants what's best for me. She just... disagrees about what that is."

"She thinks I'm ugly." Karui said it flatly, without self-pity. It was a fact, one she had known since she first entered the Anitsu compound and felt Nora's yellow eyes assess her dark skin with polite revulsion. "She thinks I'm too dark, too loud, too stubborn. She thinks I'll pollute your precious bloodline."

"She doesn't know you."

"She doesn't want to know me." Karui stepped back, breaking the almost-contact between them. "None of them do. The some of the older clans, the thirty percent who think they're better than the seventy percent of us who actually make this village run. They look at me and see a threat to their rarity, their specialness. They look at you and see something that belongs to them, that should stay pure and white and locked away in their little compound."

She was breathing hard, her temper fully engaged now, the words pouring out of her like water breaking through a dam. "You know what I see when I look at them? Weakness. That pale, bloodless skin like they haven't seen the sun in years. Those yellow eyes that look at me like I'm dirt. I see people who are scared because they're surrounded by darkness—our darkness, the darkness of the Raikage and Killer B and Darui and me and everyone else who actually has color in our skin."

"Karui—"

"Don't." She held up her hand, stopping him. "Don't defend them. Don't make excuses. I've heard it all before. 'They mean well.' 'They're just traditional.' 'They don't understand.' I don't care. I don't need their understanding. I need them to leave me alone."

Nanzo was silent for a long moment. When he spoke, his voice was different—softer, more vulnerable, the voice he used in private moments that she wasn't supposed to know about.

"What do you need from me?" he asked.

The question stopped her. She had expected argument, defense, the polished manners of the clan head protecting his own. Instead, he was looking at her with something like desperation, as if her answer mattered more than his next breath.

"I need..." She stopped, swallowed, forced herself to be honest in a way that terrified her. "I need you to stop being the Prince. Just for a moment. Just here. I need you to be Nanzo, the boy who lost his parents at ten, who was raised by a woman who loves him but doesn't understand him. I need you to be the person I bit in that forest, the person who was helpless and human and real."

He closed his eyes. When he opened them, something had changed—the mask had slipped, revealing the man beneath. "I am always helpless with you," he said quietly. "From the first moment you looked at me and saw through the gravity locks and the Wave Style and the clan head title. You saw the five-meter dead zone. You saw the cooldown periods. You saw me."

"And I bit you." Karui's hand rose to her own neck, touching the place where she wished she had a mark to match his. "I claimed you when you couldn't fight back. That wasn't fair."

"It was honest." He smiled, small and sad. "Everything with you is honest. Even when you're shouting, even when you're angry, even when you're calling me Prince with that tone that makes me want to prove you wrong. You're the only person in this village who doesn't want something from the Anitsu Clan head. You just want... me."

"I want you to be safe." The admission escaped before she could stop it. "I want you to stop carrying the weight of a dead clan on your shoulders. I want you to sleep without dreaming of waves that destroy everything you love."

He reached out then, finally, and took her hand. His fingers were cold, trembling slightly, but his grip was firm. "Stay here tonight," he said. "In the compound. I can arrange it—guest quarters, proper security. If Iwa is targeting you, you're safer with me."

"With you," she repeated. "In the Anitsu compound . Where your mother will serve me tea with her polite smile and her internal screaming about the dark girl touching her precious boy."

"She will behave," Nanzo said, and there was steel in his voice now—the clan head emerging, protective and commanding. "Or she will leave. You are my guest, Karui. My honored guest. Anyone who disrespects you disrespects me."

Karui looked at their joined hands—his pale fingers intertwined with her dark ones, the contrast stark and undeniable. She thought of Nora's internal revulsion, of the some of the older clans's gossip, of the seventy percent of the village that looked like her and accepted her as normal. She thought of the bite mark on his neck and the way he had looked at her just now, as if she were the only real thing in a world of ghosts.

"Fine," she said. "I'll stay. But I'm not sleeping in guest quarters, Prince. If you're protecting me, you do it properly. I want a room with a window that opens, and I want my sword back, and I want you to stop calling me honored guest like I'm some diplomat from Kiri."

"What do you want me to call you?"

She squeezed his hand, letting her nails bite just enough to remind him of her teeth. "Call me Karui. Just Karui. The stubborn girl who defeated you and isn't sorry."

He laughed, surprised, the sound young and genuine in a way that made her heart ache. "Karui," he said, testing it. "Just Karui."

"Better." She released his hand, stepping back, putting her armor back in place. "Now, tell me about this Iwa threat. If someone's trying to kill me, I want to know everything. And then

I want to know how we're going to make them regret it."

The mask slipped back over his features, but not completely. Something remained in his eyes, something warm and alive that hadn't been there when he entered. "Come," he said, moving toward the door. "I'll show you what we've recovered. And Karui?"

"Yes?"

"Thank you." He paused at the door, looking back at her with an expression she couldn't quite read. "For seeing me. Even when I don't deserve to be seen."

She followed him out into the corridor, her hand resting on the hilt of the sword that the ANBU reluctantly returned, and thought that this was how it started. Not with romance or gentleness, but with honesty and teeth marks and the stubborn refusal to look away from each other's damage.

This was how love began in Kumogakure, in the space between a Prince and a girl who refused to be anything less than exactly what she was.

Chapter 3: The Compound

The Anitsu Clan compound occupied the northeastern ridge of Kumogakure, a series of white stone buildings that seemed to grow from the mountain itself. Karui had been here before—once, briefly, after the forest battle when Nanzo had been recovering from her bite and she had been summoned to explain herself to the clan elders. She remembered feeling like a shadow in a snowfield, her dark skin conspicuous against the pale architecture, her loud voice echoing too loudly in the hushed corridors.

Now, walking beside Nanzo as the sun began to set, she felt that same dissonance but refused to show it. Let them stare. Let Nora Anitsulook down from whatever window she occupied and see her precious boy walking with the dark girl from the majority. Let the some of the older clans whisper about

contamination and impurity. Karui was here by invitation of the clan head himself, and she would not be ashamed.

"The main residence is this way," Nanzo said, gesturing toward the largest building, a three-story structure with curved roofs that mimicked the shape of waves. "Your quarters will be in the eastern wing. They overlook the training grounds—you'll have space to practice."

"I don't need special treatment."

"You need to be safe." He stopped at the entrance, turning to face her with an expression that was half apology, half stubbornness. "I know you can protect yourself, Karui. I've experienced your capabilities firsthand. But Iwa's weapon is something different. It targets chakra networks through resonance—if they catch you unaware, you won't have time to draw your sword."

"And you can protect me from this?"

"I can try." He reached for the door, then hesitated. "My mother will be waiting inside. She... she doesn't know you're coming. I thought it better to surprise her than to give her time to prepare objections."

Karui felt her temper flare, hot and familiar. "You didn't tell her? Nanzo, I'm not some secret to be hidden —"

"You're not a secret." He turned back to her, and she saw something desperate in his eyes. "You're the most important person in my life, and I don't know how to explain that to her. I don't know how to explain that you defeated me, that you trained me, that you see me when no one else does. So yes, I didn't tell her. Because I was afraid."

The admission shocked her into silence. Nanzo Anitsu, who controlled gravity and waves and could kill with a thought, afraid of his mother's reaction.

"Of what?" she asked quietly.

"That she would say the things you're afraid of hearing. That she would look at you with disgust, call you ugly, say you don't belong. And that I would..." He stopped, swallowed. "That I

would fail to defend you properly. That I would fall back into being the clan head, the perfect son, and let her hurt you because it's easier than fighting."

Karui stared at him. In all their complicated history, she had never heard him speak like this—raw, uncertain, admitting weakness before they even entered the battlefield. It made her want to fight for him, to stand between him and everything that wanted to break him.

"Then we'll go in together," she said, moving to stand beside him. "And if she says those things, I'll defend myself. I don't need you to fight my battles, Prince. I need you to stand with me while I fight them."

He looked at her for a long moment, something like wonder in his expression. Then he nodded, once, and opened the door.

The entrance hall was exactly as Karui remembered—white marble floors, walls painted with murals of ocean waves, the air cool and smelling of incense and old secrets. Nora Anitsu stood at the far end, arranging flowers in a tall vase, her white kimono pristine, her yellow eyes downcast.

"Mom," Nanzo said, and Karui heard the slight tremor in his voice. "We have a guest."

Nora turned. Her face was composed, beautiful in the way of porcelain dolls, but Karui saw the moment of recognition, the slight widening of eyes, the almost imperceptible tightening of her jaw. In that instant, she knew everything—knew that Nora had hoped her son would come home alone, that the rumors of his involvement with the dark girl were exaggerated, that purity could still be preserved.

"Karui-san," Nora said, her voice perfectly polite, perfectly cold. "What an unexpected pleasure."

"Nora-san." Karui bowed slightly, maintaining eye contact. "Thank you for having me. Your son insisted on my safety."

"Did he?" Nora's gaze flicked to Nanzo, and Karui saw the question in her eyes—why, why her, why this dark stubborn girl who stands out like a wound in our white world? "The eastern wing, I assume? I'll prepare the guest quarters immediately."

"Mom." Nanzo's voice was firm now, the clan head asserting himself. "Karui will dine with us tonight. In the family quarters. She is not a guest to be hidden away—she is here as my..."

He paused, searching for words. Karui watched Nora's face, saw the hope that he would say colleague, or friend, or even opponent—anything that maintained distance.

"My trusted ally," Nanzo finished. "And my teacher. She has agreed to continue my training in close combat. To address the weaknesses you yourself have noted in my defensive capabilities."

It was cleverly done, Karui had to admit. Framing her presence as practical, beneficial, aligned with Nora's own concerns for his safety. She saw Nora hesitate, the calculations running behind her yellow eyes.

"Of course," Nora said finally, her smile not reaching her eyes. "We must discuss the menu, then. Karui-san, do you have any dietary restrictions? Any... preferences?"

The pause before preferences was barely perceptible, but Karui heard it. Any preferences, as if her dark palate might be different, might require special consideration, might be somehow less refined than theirs.

"I eat what Nanzo eats," she said, deliberately using his name without honorific, watching Nora's composure crack slightly. "We've shared meals before. He knows my tastes."

The implication hung in the air—shared meals, shared space, shared intimacy that went beyond formal politeness. Nora's hands tightened on the flower she held, crushing a petal.

"Then I'll prepare his favorites," she said, her voice slightly strained. "Nanzo, perhaps you could show Karui-san to her quarters? I'll call you when dinner is ready."

She turned back to her flowers, dismissing them, and Karui felt Nanzo's hand on her elbow, guiding her toward the eastern corridor.

"That went well," she murmured as they moved out of earshot.

"She's trying," Nanzo replied, but he didn't sound convinced. "In her way, she's trying."

"She's trying to accept that I'm here without accepting that I belong here." Karui stopped at the door to her assigned room, turning to face him. "It's fine, Nanzo. I don't need her to love me. I just need her not to sabotage us while we deal with this Iwa threat."

"Us." He caught the word, held it like a precious thing. "You said us."

"We're allies, aren't we? You said so yourself." She opened the door, revealing a room that was spacious but sterile—white walls, white bedding, a single window that did indeed overlook the training grounds. "Even if I think 'trusted ally' is a coward's way of describing what we are."

"What are we, then?" He followed her into the room, closing the door behind them, and suddenly the space felt smaller, more intimate. "Tell me, Karui. Since you're so brave with words."

She dropped her pack on the bed, turning to face him. The setting sun painted the room in gold and rose, making his white skin glow, casting her own dark complexion in shadows that she knew he found beautiful. She had seen it in his eyes, that particular hunger that had nothing to do with chakra or combat.

"We're complicated," she said. "I'm the girl who defeated you when you were helpless. You're the boy who let me. We're bound by teeth marks and training sessions and the fact that neither of us knows how to be vulnerable with anyone else."

"That sounds like damage," he said quietly.

"It sounds like honesty." She stepped closer, close enough to touch, close enough to hurt. "The question is, Prince, what do you want us to be? Beyond allies, beyond teacher and student. What do you want when the doors are closed and no one's watching?"

She watched his throat work as he swallowed, watched his hand rise to touch the collar that hid her mark. "I want..." He stopped, started again. "I want to sleep without dreaming of losing everyone I love. I

want to stop being the last of my line, the precious white prize that everyone wants to possess. I want to be someone who deserves to be seen, not because of my bloodline, but because of who I choose to be."

"And who do you choose to be?"

His hand dropped from his collar, reaching out to touch her face—tentatively, as if expecting her to pull away. When she didn't, when she leaned into his palm, she felt him shudder.

"I choose to be the man who learns from you," he said. "Who grows stronger because you pushed him to grow. Who maybe, someday, could be worthy of..."

He didn't finish the sentence. Outside, a bell rang—Nora calling them to dinner, the sound sharp and intrusive. Nanzo stepped back, the moment broken, his mask sliding back into place.

"Dinner," he said, his voice slightly rough. "We should go."

Karui let him lead her out, but she touched her cheek where his hand had been, memorizing the feeling. Worthy of what, she wondered. Worthy of her? Of love? Of a life that wasn't defined by clan duty and extinct bloodlines?

She would find out, she decided. However long it took, however many dinners with Nora's cold politeness and the some of the older clans's gossip, she would find out what Nanzo Anitsu could become when he stopped being a Prince and started being a man.

Dinner was a study in controlled tension. The family quarters were smaller than the main hall, more intimate, which made Nora's presence feel larger, more oppressive. She served them with mechanical precision, her movements graceful and empty, her conversation limited to inquiries about Nanzo's day that carefully excluded Karui.

"The Raikage's summit," Nora said, pouring tea for her son—only for her son, Karui noticed. "Did Darui- sama have specific concerns?"

"Border security," Nanzo replied, his eyes flicking to Karui. "Intelligence suggests Iwa has developed new capabilities. We're analyzing the evidence."

"Iwa." Nora's lips thinned. "Your father died fighting Iwa, you know. During the Second War. Explosion Corps."

"I know, Mom."

"Such a waste." Nora set down the teapot, her hands lingering on the ceramic. "All that potential, all that bloodline purity, destroyed by crude explosives. If he had survived, if the clan had maintained its numbers..."

She didn't finish, but Karui heard the implication. If the clan had maintained its numbers, Nanzo wouldn't need to associate with outsiders. Wouldn't need to bring dark girls into their sacred spaces. Wouldn't need to dilute what remained of their precious heritage.

"The clan will survive," Nanzo said quietly. "In whatever form it needs to take."

Nora's eyes met Karui's across the table, and for a moment, the polite mask slipped. Karui saw it then— the full force of Nora's internal revulsion, the screaming thoughts that Nanzo would never hear. Ugly dark. Dark lips. Body that might scare him. Stubborn and loud. Pollution.

Karui smiled. It wasn't a nice smile. "The food is delicious, Nora-san," she said, her voice deliberately loud, deliberately present. "You have excellent skills. Nanzo is fortunate to have been raised by someone so capable."

The words were innocent, but the delivery was a challenge. I am here. I am loud. I am dark. And your son brought me here, wants me here, sees something in me that you never will.

"Thank you," Nora said, her voice tight. "I learned from my mother, who learned from hers. Our traditions go back generations."

"Traditions change," Karui replied, taking a bite of fish, chewing slowly, maintaining eye contact. "Especially when survival requires it. The Cloud Village itself is proof of

that—we've adapted, grown, incorporated new techniques and new people. That's why we're strong."

"Strength without purity is merely chaos." Nora's hand trembled slightly as she reached for her own cup. "The Anitsu Clan has endured because we maintained our standards. Our bloodline is... special. Unique. It would be tragic to lose that uniqueness through... carelessness."

"Mom." Nanzo's voice was sharp, warning.

"I'm simply making conversation," Nora said, her innocence as false as her smile. "Karui-san understands, don't you? The importance of preserving what makes us who we are?"

Karui set down her chopsticks. She thought of Kumogakure's seventy percent, of the Raikage and Killer B and all the shinobi who had built this village with their sweat and blood. She thought of Nora's fear, small and pathetic, the terror of a minority surrounded by a majority they couldn't control.

"I understand that survival requires adaptation," she said, her voice steady. "The strongest species aren't the ones who refuse to change—they're the ones who change best. Your clan has survived wars, assassinations, near-extinction. That suggests resilience, not rigidity."

"Resilience has limits."

"Everything has limits." Karui leaned forward, her amber eyes catching the lamplight. "The question is whether you recognize when you've reached them. When holding on to the past becomes more dangerous than embracing the future."

The silence stretched between them, electric and dangerous. Nanzo sat frozen, caught between the woman who raised him and the woman who saw him, and Karui felt a moment's pity for him—trapped in this white room between two kinds of love, two kinds of truth.

"Perhaps," Nora said finally, her voice barely above a whisper, "we should discuss more pleasant topics. Nanzo, tell me about your training. You mentioned close combat?"

The rest of the meal passed in safe superficialities, but Karui had made her point. She was here. She wasn't going anywhere. And Nora Anitsu would have to learn to live with the darkness in her white world, or be consumed by her own fear of it.

Later, in the silence of her assigned room, Karui stood at the window and watched the compound's training grounds below. The moon had risen, casting everything in silver and shadow, and she could see movement there—a solitary figure practicing forms with a precision that spoke of desperation.

Nanzo.

She recognized his style now, the way he moved. The long-range power that made him devastating at a distance, the careful footwork that maintained the five-meter safety zone, the slight hesitation that revealed his lingering discomfort with physical contact. She had trained that hesitation out of him, or started to. She had taught him to embrace the closeness that had once been his weakness.

Now, watching him move through kata after kata, she saw something new. Anger, perhaps. Or fear. The Iwa threat, his mother's barely veiled hostility, the weight of being clan head in a world that wanted to break him.

She grabbed her sword and went to join him.

He didn't stop when she approached, didn't acknowledge her presence, but she saw his movements shift slightly—becoming more deliberate, more performative. Showing off, even now.

"Your stance is wrong," she said, when he completed a sequence.

"Is it?" He lowered his arms, breathing hard. "I was practicing what you taught me."

"You were practicing what you think I want to see." She circled him, assessing. "You're tense. Your shoulders are up, your weight is back. You're preparing to retreat before you've even engaged."

"I'm preparing to maintain distance. My advantage."

"Your advantage is also your prison." She stopped in front of him, close enough to strike, close enough to be struck. "In the forest, you locked me with gravity. You thought you'd won. But you forgot the cooldowns. You forgot that power without adaptability becomes helplessness."

"I haven't forgotten." His eyes met hers, yellow against amber, pale against dark. "I think about that day every moment. Your teeth in my neck. The way you looked at me when I couldn't fight back. Like I was finally real."

"You were helpless."

"I was seen." He reached out, his hand hovering near her shoulder, asking permission. When she didn't move away, he touched her—lightly, reverently. "You saw Nanzo. Not the clan head, not the last heir, not the precious white prize. Just me. Weak and human and defeated."

"And you hated me for it."

"I loved you for it." The words hung between them, stark and irretrievable. "I didn't understand that then. I thought I was angry, humiliated, betrayed by my own techniques. But really, I was in love with the first person who ever made me feel like I could be something other than what I was born to be."

Karui felt her breath catch. In all their time together, through all the training and the arguments and the complicated silences, he had never said this so plainly.

"Nanzo..."

"I know it's not what you want to hear." He withdrew his hand, stepping back, putting distance between them. "I know you see me as a student, or a project, or maybe just an opponent who happened to be useful. But I need you to know that when I asked you to stay tonight, it wasn't just about Iwa or security or political necessity. It was because I can't bear to be in this place, surrounded by ghosts and expectations, without the one person who makes me feel alive."

He turned away, his shoulders tight, his voice dropping to something broken. "You don't have to say anything. You don't have to feel anything. Just... know. And if you want to leave

tomorrow, if this is too

much, too complicated, too damaged, I'll understand. I'll protect you from Iwa regardless. But I needed to tell you the truth, just once, while I had the courage."

Karui stood in the moonlight, listening to him breathe, feeling the weight of everything he had said. Love. He had said love. Not alliance, not gratitude, not the dependency of a student for a teacher. Love, with all its terror and its hope.

She thought of Nora inside, dreaming of white purity and yellow-eyed grandchildren. She thought of the village gossip, the some of the older clans's fear, the seventy percent who looked like her and would accept her without question. She thought of her own stubborn heart, guarded and defensive, that had never let anyone close enough to hurt it.

Then she thought of Nanzo in the forest, helpless and human and finally real, and how she had marked him not just as victory but as claim.

"You're an idiot," she said, stepping close behind him. "A romantic, foolish idiot who reads too much into combat outcomes."

He stiffened, preparing for rejection. "Karui—"

"And I'm apparently an idiot too," she continued, "because I've been in love with you since you looked at me after I bit you, and you didn't hate me. Since you asked me to train you instead of punishing me. Since you started looking at me like I was beautiful instead of dangerous."

She turned him around, her hands on his shoulders, forcing him to face her. "So yes, Nanzo. I'll stay. Not because of Iwa or security or political necessity. Because I want to be here, with you, in this white compound full of ghosts, making our own future out of the wreckage of the past."

His eyes were wide, disbelieving, hope warring with fear. "You love me?"

"I love the man you become when you're not trying to be perfect. The one who admits he's afraid, who asks for help, who

sleeps in my lap and tells me my smell is his addiction." She smiled, feeling the truth of it settle into her bones. "I love you, you ridiculous Prince. Now stop looking at me like I'm going to disappear and kiss me properly."

He did. It was awkward at first—he was inexperienced, she was impatient, their noses bumped and their teeth clicked—but then his hands found her waist and her fingers tangled in his hair and the world narrowed to just this: dark and pale, stubborn and scared, two damaged people choosing each other against all reason.

When they finally broke apart, both breathing hard, Nanzo rested his forehead against hers. "Nora can't know," he whispered. "Not yet. If she suspects, if she thinks I'm serious about you, she'll... I don't know what she'll do. But it won't be rational."

"She already suspects." Karui traced the line of his jaw, memorizing the shape of him. "She looks at me and sees everything she fears. But she doesn't see what I see."

"And what's that?"

"Possibility." Karui stepped back, taking his hand, leading him toward the practice dummies. "Come. Show me what you've been working on. And tomorrow, we'll start planning how to deal with Iwa together. As partners."

"Partners," he repeated, tasting the word.

"Partners," she confirmed. "In combat, in life, in everything. If you'll have me."

He looked at her—really looked, with the yellow eyes that marked him as Anitsu blood, seeing her dark skin and her stubborn jaw and her love that didn't know how to be gentle. "I'll have you," he said. "In whatever form you'll come. Dark, stubborn, loud, and perfect."

They trained until dawn, and if Nora watched from the windows, if she saw her son laughing with the dark girl, touching her hand between forms, looking at her with an expression that had never been directed at anything in their white world—she didn't say a word.

But Karui felt her watching. And she knew that this was only the beginning of the war.

Chapter 4: The Cipher of Waves

Three days later, Nanzo stood in the Anitsu Clan's underground laboratory, surrounded by equipment that had belonged to his father, his grandfather, generations of Wave Style masters who had died to keep their secrets safe. The metal fragment from Iwa sat on the central table, still vibrating with that disturbing resonance, still whispering of secrets that shouldn't exist.

"Well?" Karui asked from the doorway. She had refused to stay in the compound while he worked, insisting on being present for any breakthrough. "Have you cracked it?"

"Partially." He didn't look up from his notes, his hand moving in precise calculations that she recognized from his academy days—physics, he had told her once, was the foundation of everything he did. Chakra was energy, energy followed laws, and understanding those laws made him dangerous in ways that brute force never could.

"The frequency matches our Wave Style," he continued, "but it's crude. Artificial. They've found a way to simulate the harmonic signature without the actual bloodline. It's like... a recording of a song, played through bad speakers. Recognizable, but distorted."

"Can they use it against us?"

"Against me, specifically." He finally looked up, his eyes shadowed with exhaustion. "The resonance is tuned to my chakra signature. They must have obtained a sample—blood, hair, something from the Second War, maybe. If they deploy this in combat, it could disrupt my Wave Style, cause feedback loops, potentially kill me from internal resonance."

Karui felt cold fear settle in her stomach. "Then we need to change your signature. Or develop a counter-frequency."

"I've already started." He gestured to a complex array of seals on the far wall, glowing with contained energy. "I'm adapting our clan's sealing techniques. If I can create a wave-cancelling field, similar to noise-reduction in acoustics..."

"You're going to seal your own chakra?"

"Temporarily. Just enough to shift my harmonic signature outside their targeting range." He moved to the seal array, his fingers tracing the patterns with absent familiarity. "It's risky. If I miscalculate, I could seal my Wave Style permanently. Or worse, create a resonance cascade that destroys the compound."

"Then don't do it alone." Karui crossed to stand beside him, studying the seals that meant nothing to her but everything to him. "You said we're partners. Partners don't let each other take stupid risks."

"This isn't stupid. It's necessary."

"It's stupid if you die trying." She caught his hand, stopping his tracing. "Let me help. I don't understand the wave mechanics, but I understand combat risk. I can monitor your vitals, watch for signs of distress. I can pull you out if something goes wrong."

He looked at their joined hands, her dark fingers wrapped around his pale ones, and she saw him waver. "If something goes wrong, you could be hurt. The resonance doesn't discriminate—it will affect anyone in range."

"Then I'll stay at the edge of the range. Five meters, right? Your dead zone." She squeezed his hand. "Let me be your safety, Nanzo. Let me do this for you."

The words echoed between them, loaded with memory. In the forest, he had been helpless in his dead zone, unable to use his powers, vulnerable to her attack. Now she was offering to enter that space deliberately, to be his vulnerability and his protection.

"You're sure?" he asked.

"I've never been more sure of anything."

He nodded, once, and began to explain the procedure. The seals would activate in sequence, creating a harmonic field that would interact with his chakra network. She would monitor his heart rate, his breathing, the color of his skin—any sign that the resonance was overwhelming his system. If she saw danger, she would break the central seal, aborting the process.

"Whatever happens," he said, as he positioned himself in the seal array's center, "don't enter the field. If I lose control, the waves could liquefy your internal organs before you realized you were in danger."

"Promises, promises," she muttered, but her voice was tight with fear.

He smiled, that rare genuine smile that transformed his face from clan head to human being. "I love you," he said, simply, as if it were a weapon or a shield or a prayer.

"I love you too," she replied. "Now stop stalling and do the thing."

The seals activated with a sound like breaking glass, high and sharp and wrong. Nanzo's body went rigid, his yellow eyes widening, his hands clenching into fists. Karui watched from her position at the five-meter mark, her eyes tracking every detail—his breathing, too fast; his skin, too pale; the veins standing out on his neck as his chakra fought against the artificial resonance.

"Steady," she called out, though he probably couldn't hear her. "You're doing fine. Stay with me."

The metal fragment on the table began to vibrate violently, responding to the field. Nanzo gasped, a sound of pain that tore at her resolve, but she held her position. Trust the plan. Trust his calculations. Trust that love was stronger than physics.

Then something went wrong.

The seals flared blinding white, and Nanzo screamed—a raw, broken sound that she had never heard from him before. The resonance was overwhelming him, feeding back on itself, creating a loop that grew stronger with each passing second. She saw blood begin to trickle from his nose, his ears, the

corners of his eyes.

"Nanzo!" She took a step forward, then forced herself back. Five meters. The dead zone. If she entered, she would die, and he would be alone.

But if she didn't enter, he would die anyway.

She made her choice.

Karui sprinted forward, crossing the five-meter mark, feeling the wave pressure hit her like a physical blow. Her ears rang, her vision blurred, but she kept moving, reaching Nanzo, grabbing his shoulders, shaking him with all her strength.

"Break the seal!" she shouted, her voice barely audible over the harmonic scream. "Nanzo, break the central seal! Now!"

His eyes focused on her, bloodshot and terrified. "Karui... you shouldn't..."

"Break it, you idiot! That's an order!"

His hand moved, sluggish, fighting against the resonance that wanted to keep him trapped. His fingers found the central seal, the anchor point of the entire array, and with a final surge of will, he shattered it.

The silence that followed was absolute.

The seals went dark. The metal fragment stopped vibrating. Nanzo collapsed against her, his full weight falling into her arms, and she lowered them both to the ground, checking his pulse, his breathing, the dilation of his eyes.

"You're okay," she whispered, more prayer than statement. "You're okay. I've got you. You're okay."

"You're bleeding," he murmured, his hand rising to touch her face. She felt wetness there—her nose, her ears, the same resonance damage she had risked to save him.

"So are you." She laughed, slightly hysterical. "We're a matched set. Damaged and stubborn and alive."

He closed his eyes, his head resting against her chest, and she felt him relax into her hold. "You entered the dead zone," he said, wonderingly. "You knew it could kill you, and you entered

anyway."

"Someone had to save your stupid life." She stroked his hair, her hands trembling. "Don't ever scare me like that again, Nanzo. I mean it. Next time you want to experiment with potentially lethal chakra resonance, you clear it with me first."

"Yes, ma'am." He smiled against her, the expression tired but genuine. "My stubborn, loud, beautiful protector."

They stayed like that for a long time, two damaged people in a basement full of secrets, holding each other together against a world that wanted to tear them apart. And somewhere above them, Nora Anitsu stood in the shadows of the corridor, having seen everything, her yellow eyes wide with a terrible understanding.

She had seen her son collapse. She had seen the dark girl run into danger to save him. She had seen love, raw and undeniable, in the space where purity was supposed to reign.

And she didn't know what to do with it.

Chapter 5: The Mission of Broken Things

The intelligence came three days later, delivered by a tired-looking Omoi who had clearly run all the way from the Raikage's office.

"Iwa's agent," he gasped, leaning against the compound's doorframe. "We've identified them. Or rather, they've identified themselves. Left a message at the eastern checkpoint."

Nanzo took the proffered scroll, his expression carefully neutral. Karui stood beside him, her hand resting on her sword hilt, ready for whatever came next.

The message was simple, written in the same cipher they had intercepted before:

"The white prize grows tarnished. The dark contamination spreads. Meet us at the Falls of Truth, or we will cleanse both."

"They're threatening to expose you," Karui said, reading over his shoulder. "To the village, to the white minority, to everyone. They know about us."

"They know I care for you," Nanzo corrected, but his voice was hollow. "They don't know you return the feeling. They think you're leverage, a weakness to be exploited."

"Then let's exploit their misunderstanding." Karui turned to Omoi. "Darui-sama's orders?"

"He wants a team. Discrete, no official affiliation. If this goes wrong, Kumogakure needs deniability." Omoi straightened, his usual worry replaced by professional focus. "Samui-san's handling the border patrol rotation to cover our absence. I'm your backup."

"And me?" Karui asked.

"You're the target." Nanzo rolled the scroll, his jaw tight. "They want to use you against me. So we let them think they can. I go to the meeting, you follow in stealth, Omoi provides overwatch from the ridge."

"It's a trap," Omoi said.

"Obviously." Nanzo smiled, but it wasn't a pleasant expression. "But traps work both ways. They want to catch me in a compromising position, something that will destroy my standing with the some of the older clans and weaken the clan. I intend to give them exactly what they want—just not the way they expect."

Karui studied his face, seeing the calculation there, the strategic mind that had always existed beneath the clan head persona. "You have a plan."

"I have physics." He moved to the weapon rack, selecting a sword—not his usual style, but something closer to what she had taught him. "And I have the best close-combat instructor in Kumogakure. If they want to fight in the Falls of Truth, they'll find that water conducts sound waves beautifully. And sound waves, properly applied, can shatter stone."

The Falls of Truth were located in the northern mountains, a day's travel from the village. Legend said that the water showed travelers their true selves, stripping away illusions and lies. Karui had always thought it was sentimental nonsense, but standing at the base of the falls as Nanzo approached the meeting point, she felt the weight of truth pressing down on her.

She was hidden in the spray, her dark skin camouflaged against the wet rocks, her chakra suppressed to nothing. Omoi was somewhere above, his position undetectable even to her trained senses. And Nanzo—her Nanzo, her love, her partner—walked openly into the clearing, wearing his white robes like a target.

The Iwa agent revealed themselves with theatrical flair. Three figures, masked, their chakra signatures masked by some technique that made them feel like holes in the world rather than presences. They

surrounded Nanzo in a triangle, maintaining careful distance—ten meters, she noted, just outside his optimal gravity range.

"Anitsu-sama," the lead figure said, their voice distorted by a vocal modifier. "How kind of you to accept our invitation."

"I don't respond well to threats against those I care about." Nanzo's voice was calm, aristocratic, the perfect performance of a concerned clan head. "State your demands."

"Simple. You will publicly denounce the dark girl Karui. Declare her unfit for association with noble blood. Destroy any reputation she has as a competent shinobi, make her a pariah in her own village." The figure laughed, the sound grating. "Or we will release evidence of your... indiscretion. The late-night training sessions. The shared meals. The way you look at her when you think no one sees."

"And if I comply?"

"Then your secret dies with us. The some of the older clans maintains their illusion of purity. The Anitsu Clan remains... unsullied." The figure's tone made the word sound filthy. "It's a small price, isn't it? One dark girl's future for your clan's

reputation?"

Nanzo was silent for a long moment. Karui watched him from her hiding place, her heart hammering against her ribs, her hand white-knuckled on her sword. She knew this was part of the plan. She knew he was acting. But the words still hurt, the possibility that he might choose purity over her, tradition over love.

"You're right," Nanzo said finally. "It is a small price. Too small, perhaps."

He moved.

Not with gravity—he didn't need to. Not with Wave Style—he was saving that. He moved with the taijutsu she had taught him, closing the distance to the nearest agent in a burst of speed that spoke of physics applied to human muscle, of vectors and force and the beautiful mathematics of violence.

His sword struck before the agent could react, not to kill but to disable—a precise cut to the tendons of the wrist, dropping the weapon, followed by a sweep that took the legs. The agent fell, screaming, their mask dislodging to reveal a face that Karui didn't recognize but Nanzo clearly did.

"Kiriwara," he said, standing over the fallen agent. "Iwa's deep cover operative. You've been in Kumogakure for five years, posing as a merchant. I analyzed your chakra signature three days ago, matched it to the resonance on the metal fragment."

The remaining two agents attacked simultaneously, but Nanzo was already moving, dancing between them with a grace that made Karui's heart swell with pride. This was her teaching, her training, transformed by his genius into something unique. Close combat, once his weakness, now his unexpected strength.

She emerged from her hiding place, her sword clearing its sheath with a sound like a promise. The second agent turned to face her, and she saw their eyes widen behind the mask—surprise that the target was armed, that the leverage had teeth.

"Wrong assumption," she said, and attacked.

The fight was brief and brutal. These were spies, not frontline combatants, and they had prepared for a clan head who relied on long-range techniques. They had not prepared for a partnership, for love translated into coordinated violence, for physics and steel working in perfect harmony.

When it was over, two agents were unconscious, one was bleeding from a wound that would need immediate attention, and Nanzo stood in the center of the clearing, his white robes splattered with mud and blood, his chest heaving, his eyes bright with something that looked like joy.

"Partners," he said, looking at her.

"Partners," she agreed, lowering her sword.

Omoi descended from the ridge, his expression impressed despite himself. "Well," he said, surveying the carnage. "That was... efficient."

"Physics," Nanzo said, cleaning his blade with a cloth that appeared from his sleeve. "And excellent training. Karui, remind me to thank you properly later."

"Oh, I'll remind you." She sheathed her sword, moving to stand beside him, not touching but close enough to feel his heat. "So what now? We have prisoners, intelligence about Iwa's operations, and proof that they were trying to blackmail a clan head. Darui-sama will want a full report."

"Darui-sama will want more than that." Nanzo looked at the prisoners, his expression shifting from warrior to statesman. "These three are the beginning. Iwa has been infiltrating our village for years, playing on the divisions between some of the older clans and the many in the village. They've been feeding the gossip, encouraging the prejudice, trying to destabilize us from within."

"Using you as the wedge," Karui realized.

"Using us." He turned to face her, his yellow eyes serious. "Our relationship—real or perceived—was their weapon. They thought that threatening you would control me. They thought that destroying your reputation would break me." He reached out, taking her hand, ignoring Omoi's presence, ignoring

everything but the truth between them. "They were wrong. You are not my weakness, Karui. You are my strength. The reason I fight, the reason I grow, the reason I refuse to be just what I was born to be."

"Nanzo..." She felt tears prick her eyes, stubborn and unwelcome. "We're in the middle of a mission. Omoi is right there."

"Omoi is a trusted comrade who understands that some things are more important than propriety." Nanzo raised her hand to his lips, pressing a kiss to her knuckles. "I love you. I will say it in front of the Raikage, in front of my mother, in front of the entire village. I am Nanzo Anitsu, clan head, survivor, and I am in love with Karui of Kumogakure, the stubborn dark girl who defeated me and made me whole."

Omoi coughed, looking studiously at the sky. "I'll, uh, secure the prisoners. Take your time."

Karui laughed, the sound breaking through her tears, and pulled Nanzo into a kiss that tasted of blood and victory and the beginning of something that could not be stopped.

The Falls of Truth roared behind them, and if the water showed them their true selves, they were brave enough to look.

Chapter 6: The Announcement

They returned to Kumogakure as dawn broke over the mountains, their prisoners secured, their report prepared, their hands clasped together where anyone could see. The village was waking, the dark majority beginning their daily routines, the some of the older clans stirring in their privileged compounds.

Darui received them in his private chambers, his expression unreadable as he listened to their report. When they finished, he sat in silence for a long moment, his fingers steepled beneath his chin.

"Iwa has been playing a long game," he said finally. "Using our own divisions against us. It's clever. Cruel, but clever."

"We can use this," Nanzo said. "The prisoners will talk. We can trace their network, expose the other agents, turn their strategy back on them."

"And the personal element?" Darui's eyes moved between them, noting their joined hands, the matching bruises, the way they stood slightly too close. "The blackmail attempt, the threat to Karui-san?"

"Was unsuccessful." Nanzo's grip tightened on her fingers. "As it will always be unsuccessful. I am making a formal declaration, Darui-sama. Karui and I are... together. Partners. In all things. Anyone who threatens her threatens me, and I will respond with the full force of the Anitsu Clan."

"Your mother?"

"Will learn to accept it. Or she will learn to live with disappointment." Nanzo's voice was steel. "I am clan head. My choices are mine to make. And I choose her."

Darui studied them for a long moment, then smiled—that rare, genuine expression that transformed his face from lazy politician to legendary shinobi. "About time," he said. "The village has been taking bets on when you'd make it official. I had three weeks from today in the pool."

Karui felt her jaw drop. "You knew?"

"Everyone knew, kid." Darui rose, moving to the window. "The way you two look at each other? It's not subtle. The only question was whether Nanzo would grow the spine to admit it publicly." He turned back, his expression serious. "But know this—making it official changes things. The some of the older clans will react. There will be pressure, gossip, maybe threats. Are you prepared for that?"

"We are," they said together, and Karui felt the rightness of it, the unity that made them stronger than either could be alone.

"Then go," Darui said. "Make your announcement. Deal with the fallout. And when you're ready, come back to me with a plan for rooting out Iwa's network. We'll need the Anitsu Clan's unique capabilities— and your partner's particular skills."

They left the Raikage's tower into the full morning light, and Nanzo turned to her with a question in his eyes. "Publicly?" he asked. "Now?"

"Now," she confirmed. "No more hiding. No more pretending to be allies or teacher and student. We walk through the village together, and we let them see."

They walked.

Through the market districts, where vendors called out greetings to Karui and fell silent when they saw her hand in Nanzo's. Through the training grounds, where Killer B looked up from his rap practice and flashed them a thumbs-up that suggested he had known all along. Through the administrative quarter, where some of the older clans officials stared and whispered and turned away with expressions of disgust.

Karui held her head high, her amber eyes challenging anyone who dared meet her gaze. She was dark, she was stubborn, she was loud, and she was loved by the most powerful clan head in Kumogakure. Let them whisper. Let the thirty percent feel their minority status acutely, surrounded by the seventy percent who looked like her and accepted her as one of their own.

At the Anitsu compound gates, they paused. Nora would be inside, preparing breakfast, perhaps, or arranging flowers, or engaging in any of the countless rituals that maintained the illusion of a world that no longer existed.

"Together," Nanzo said.

"Together," she agreed.

They entered.

Nora met them in the main hall, her posture perfect, her face a mask of polite inquiry. But Karui saw the moment she noticed their joined hands, the slight widening of her yellow eyes, the way her fingers tightened on the fan she carried.

"Nanzo," she said, her voice carefully neutral. "You're back early. I wasn't expecting you until—"

"Mom." He released Karui's hand, but only to place his arm around her shoulders, drawing her close. "Karui and I have

something to tell you. Something the village will know by nightfall."

Nora's fan snapped open, hiding the lower half of her face. "I see."

"We're together. Romantically. Partners in life as well as combat." He spoke quickly, as if speed could soften the blow. "I love her. She loves me. We're going to build a future together, here in this compound, with the clan. And I need you to accept that. Not just tolerate it—accept it. Because she is going to be my wife, and the mother of my children, and your daughter-in-law, and I will not have her treated as anything less than family."

The silence stretched between them, heavy and dangerous. Karui felt Nora's eyes on her, assessing, judging, seeing all the things she had always seen: dark skin, stubborn jaw, loud presence, the pollution of purity.

Then Nora closed her fan. Her hands were trembling.

"You've made your choice," she said, her voice barely above a whisper.

"I have."

"And if I cannot accept it? If I look at her and see everything that will destroy what your father died to protect?"

"Then you will lose me too." Nanzo's voice was gentle but unyielding. "I don't want that. I love you, Mom. You've raised me, trained me, been my family when I had no one. But I am not a child anymore. I am clan head, and I choose her. I choose life and change and a future that isn't defined by blood purity and extinct traditions. And if that choice excludes you, I will grieve. But I will not change it."

Nora looked at him—really looked—and Karui saw something break in her expression. The mask of the perfect mother, the guardian of purity, cracked to reveal the woman beneath: afraid, grieving, loving her son so much that it had become a kind of poison.

"I need time," Nora said finally. "Time to... to understand. To see what you see in her."

"Take the time you need." Nanzo stepped forward, embracing his mother, and Karui saw Nora stiffen before slowly, reluctantly, returning the gesture. "But know that she is part of my life now. Part of our family. And I believe, if you let yourself, you could come to love her too."

Nora's eyes met Karui's over Nanzo's shoulder, and in them Karui saw no love, no acceptance—only a desperate, drowning fear. But there was something else too, something that might grow into tolerance, if not affection: the recognition that Karui loved him too, that she had risked her life for him, that she was not the monster Nora had imagined.

"We'll see," Nora said. And for now, that was enough.

Chapter 7: The Wedding of Waves

Six months later, Kumogakure celebrated the wedding of Nanzo Anitsu and Karui of the Hidden Cloud.

It was not the wedding the some of the older clans had envisioned for their precious Prince. There was no weeks-long purification ritual, no exclusive guest list of pale-skinned nobility, no emphasis on the preservation of bloodline purity. Instead, the ceremony was held in the village's central plaza, open to all, with Darui himself officiating and Killer B providing entertainment that was arguably inappropriate for a formal occasion.

Karui wore white—a deliberate choice, a claiming of the color that had always been used to exclude her. Her dress was simple, cut for movement rather than display, and she carried her sword instead of flowers. Her skin glowed dark against the silk, her amber eyes defiant, her red hair crowned with a circlet of silver waves that Nanzo had designed himself.

Nanzo wore black. The color of the majority, of the village that had raised her, of the future they were building together. His

white skin seemed to shine against it, his yellow eyes bright with an emotion that made Karui's heart ache. Around his neck, visible to all, was the scar from her bite—the mark she had given him when he was helpless, now displayed as proudly as any medal.

The vows they wrote themselves, rejecting the traditional Anitsu Clan language of purity and preservation in favor of something new:

"I take you not to maintain what was, but to create what will be," Nanzo said, his voice carrying across the silent crowd. "Not as master and servant, not as purity and pollution, but as partners. Equals. Two waves that meet and merge and become something stronger than either alone."

"I take you not despite your darkness, but because of it," Karui replied, her voice steady despite the tears she refused to shed. "Not to tame you or change you, but to grow with you. To fight beside you, to challenge you, to love you in all your complicated, stubborn, beautiful humanity."

When they kissed, the crowd erupted—majority cheering their own, some of the older clans watching in stunned silence, the village acknowledging that something fundamental had shifted. The Anitsu Clan was no longer an isolated bastion of purity. It was changing, adapting, becoming part of the larger world.

And in the front row, Nora Anitsu stood with her hands clasped so tightly that her knuckles were white, watching her son smile in a way she had never seen before, watching the dark girl who had somehow made him whole, and trying—truly trying—to find happiness in his happiness.

Later, at the reception, she approached Karui alone. The new bride was watching Nanzo dance with Killer B—an absurd spectacle that involved too much enthusiasm and questionable rhythm—and her expression was soft in a way that Nora had never seen directed at her.

"Karui-san," Nora said, the honorific feeling strange in her mouth.

"Nora-san." Karui turned, her defenses immediately rising, her body shifting into a combat-ready stance that was probably unconscious.

"I wanted to give you something." Nora held out a small box, her hands steady through sheer force of will. "It belonged to Nanzo's mother. She wore it on her wedding day, and her mother before her. I had thought... I had hoped to give it to a bride who matched our... our standards. But I was wrong. About many things."

Karui took the box, opening it to reveal a necklace—simple, elegant, a pendant shaped like a wave that seemed to move when the light hit it. "It's beautiful."

"It is tradition," Nora said carefully. "But tradition can change. You are changing it. And I am trying to change with it. For him. Because he loves you, and I love him, and perhaps... perhaps that is enough."

Karui looked at her—really looked—and saw the effort it cost, the battle that Nora was fighting against her own prejudice, her own fear. It wasn't acceptance. It wasn't even true tolerance. But it was a beginning.

"Thank you," Karui said, and meant it. She fastened the necklace around her throat, the wave pendant resting against her dark skin, and saw Nora's eyes widen slightly at the contrast—the white gold against her complexion, the traditional symbol worn in a new way. "I'll take care of him. I promise. Not because he needs protecting, but because we protect each other."

"I know," Nora whispered. "I have seen it. In the laboratory, when you ran into the resonance field. In the missions, when you fight together. You make him stronger. I cannot deny that, even when I wish to."

She turned to leave, but Karui stopped her with a hand on her arm. "Nora-san. I don't expect you to love me. I don't even expect you to like me. But I hope, someday, you might respect me. As a shinobi, as a partner to your son, as someone who is trying to build something good in this broken world."

Nora looked at the hand on her arm—dark fingers against her white sleeve, the physical reality of their difference that she had always found so threatening. Then she did something that surprised them both: she covered Karui's hand with her own, briefly, a gesture of acknowledgment.

"Respect," she said, tasting the word. "Yes. I think... I think I can manage respect. In time."

She left then, moving through the crowd toward the compound's quiet interior, and Karui watched her go with complex emotions. The war wasn't over. Nora still looked at her and saw darkness, still feared the future, still struggled with the minority's terror of being overwhelmed. But there was a truce now, a space for possibility, and that was more than Karui had expected.

"She spoke to you." Nanzo appeared at her side, slightly breathless from dancing, his yellow eyes concerned.

"She gave me your mother's necklace." Karui touched the pendant. "And she promised to try. That's something, isn't it?"

"That's everything." He drew her into his arms, beginning to move with the music, his body swaying against hers. "Thank you. For being patient with her. For not giving up on this family, even when it would be easier to walk away."

"I don't walk away from fights," Karui reminded him, resting her head against his shoulder. "And I don't walk away from you. We're partners, remember? Stubborn, damaged, complicated partners, bound by teeth marks and training sessions and the stubborn refusal to be what everyone expects."

"Till death," he whispered.

"And beyond," she promised.

The music swelled around them, the celebration of a village that was learning to change, and in the center of the dance floor, dark and pale, stubborn and scared, they moved together as one.

VOLUME II: THE SHADOWS OF SHIBAI

Chapter 8: The Secret of Origins

One year after the wedding, Nanzo stood in the deepest chamber of the Anitsu compound, a space that existed on no map and was known only to the clan head. The walls were covered in seals that predated the village itself, written in a language that was not quite of this world, describing truths that could break minds unprepared for them.

He was not supposed to bring anyone here. The secret of the Anitsu Clan's origin was for the clan head alone, passed down through generations in a chain of knowledge that stretched back to the Ōtsutsuki themselves.

But Karui stood beside him, her hand in his, and he had promised her partnership in all things.

"Shibai Ōtsutsuki," he said, his voice echoing in the sealed space. "The progenitor. The source of our Wave Style, our yellow eyes, our connection to the fundamental forces of the universe. Our bloodline is not just a mutation or evolution—it is inheritance. Direct, unbroken, from a being that transcended this world."

Karui stared at the walls, at the images that seemed to move when viewed from the corner of one's eye. "You're saying your clan is descended from gods?"

"From one god. One who experimented on this world, who left behind fragments of power that became what we call Kekkei Genkai." Nanzo touched the central seal, feeling it pulse in recognition of his blood. "The Uchiha have their Sharingan from another branch. The Hyūga their Byakugan. And we... we have the waves. The ability to manipulate the fundamental vibrations of reality."

"Why are you telling me this?" Karui turned to face him, her amber eyes serious. "This is clan head knowledge. Sacred, secret, all those things."

"Because there is more." He led her to a pedestal at the chamber's center, upon which rested a scroll that seemed to absorb light rather than reflect it. "The Waver Mode. Our ultimate technique. Only two people in history have ever used it—the founder, and potentially me."

He unrolled the scroll, revealing diagrams that made Karui's head ache to look at. Chakra pathways that shouldn't exist, techniques that required the user to become something other than human, to merge with the wave nature of reality itself.

"It grants godlike power," Nanzo continued, his voice hollow. "Control over all waves within a two-hundred-kilometer radius. Chakra, sound, electromagnetic, seismic—everything. For thirty minutes, the user is effectively invincible. And then they die. The body cannot sustain that level of transformation. It burns out, consumes itself, leaves nothing but ash."

Karui felt cold fear spread through her chest. "You've never used it."

"No."

"And you never will."

Nanzo was silent.

"Nanzo." She grabbed his shoulders, forcing him to look at her. "Promise me. Promise me you will never use this. Not for the village, not for me, not for anything. Promise me."

"I can't promise that." His eyes were wet, desperate. "If the village is destroyed, if you're threatened, if there's no other way... Karui, I would give anything to protect you. Even my life. Especially my life."

"Then find another way!" She shook him, her temper breaking through. "You're the smartest person I know. You understand physics, chakra dynamics, sealing techniques that no one else has even imagined. Find another way to be strong that doesn't involve killing yourself!"

"I'm trying!" He pulled her close, burying his face in her hair, his body shaking. "I'm trying, Karui. I've been researching alternatives, training to increase my base power, developing

new techniques so I'll never need the Waver Mode. But I need you to understand—if it comes to that choice, if it's the only way to save you, I will use it. And I need you to forgive me in advance for that choice."

She held him, feeling his fear and his love and his desperate, stubborn willingness to sacrifice everything for her safety. And she made a silent vow, there in the chamber of secrets, that she would never let that choice become necessary. That she would fight beside him, protect him, challenge him to find another way, until the day they both died of old age in each other's arms.

"I don't forgive you," she said finally. "But I understand you. And I will fight you on this, Nanzo. Every day, every mission, every threat. I will be strong enough that you never need to consider that scroll. I will be your partner in truth, not just in words."

"That's all I ask," he whispered. "Just... stay with me. Keep me human. Keep me from becoming a god, even when the power tempts me."

"I promise," she said. And unlike his impossible promise, hers was one she knew she could keep.

They both sleep in bed.

Atmosphere: Pre-dawn darkness, rain against windows, Nanzo and Karui asleep in shared bed

The Descent

Nanzo was dreaming of waves.

Not the violent, destructive waves of his clan's techniques, but gentle ocean waves—rhythmic, eternal, the sound his mother must have heard in the womb before she died protecting him. He was floating in an endless golden sea, weightless, peaceful.

Then the sea turned inside out.

The water became sky. The sky became flesh. Nanzo found himself standing on a surface that was simultaneously stone, cloud, and the surface of an eye—massive, lidless, blinking in slow, geological time.

He knew this place.

The Ōtsutsuki Dimension. The realm of gods.

"Finally."

The voice didn't speak—it resonated. It vibrated through every atom of Nanzo's being, making his teeth ache, his bones hum, his Wave Style chakra scream in recognition. This was no Genjutsu. No ordinary

mind technique.

This was a direct neural transmission from a being that existed beyond conventional reality.

Nanzo turned.

Shibai Ōtsutsuki stood—or rather, existed—before him.

The progenitor of the Anitsu Clan's secret bloodline. The being whose divine DNA had been passed down through centuries, mutating into the Wave Style Kekkei Genkai. The god who had abandoned his mortal shell to become pure chakra, pure will, pure hunger.

He had no fixed form. He was a silhouette of golden light and absolute darkness, shifting between humanoid shapes and geometric impossibilities—sometimes with horns, sometimes with the Rinnegan's concentric rings, sometimes with nothing at all but a pressure that made Nanzo's soul want to kneel.

"Nanzo Anitsu." The name was a caress and a command. "My youngest son's most stubborn descendant. Do you know how long I have watched you?"

Nanzo's hands moved instinctively to form seals, but he had no hands here—only concept. He was thought. He was dream-stuff. He was vulnerable.

"Since your mother burned herself to protect you." Shibai's form flickered, showing a ghost-image of Nyoko's Final Resonance—her body dissolving into golden light. "Such waste. Such delicious, desperate waste. She could have been so much more."

"Don't you DARE speak of her." Nanzo's voice—his dream-voice—crackled with Wave Style resonance. Even here, even disembodied, his chakra remembered its nature. The

golden sea around them rippled with his anger.

Shibai laughed. The sound was supernovas dying. It was the silence between heartbeats. It was every nightmare Nanzo had ever suppressed since the massacre.

"Brave. Foolish. You have always been my favorite flavor of descendant." The god-thing circled him, leaving trails of stardust and decay. "Do you know why the Uchiha truly attacked your clan? Why Fugaku feared you?"

Nanzo said nothing. His dream-heart was pounding.

"Because I whispered to him." Shibai's voice dropped to an intimate, horrible intimacy. "In his Mangekyō dreams. I showed him the future where Anitsu Clan children grew strong enough to disrupt not just Genjutsu... but Divine Techniques. The techniques of gods. My techniques."

The revelation hit Nanzo like a physical blow. "You... you caused the massacre?"

"I encouraged it." Shibai's form split into a smile with too many teeth. "Your clan was becoming too numerous. Too visible. The Wave Style was evolving beyond my design—your mother's Final Resonance touched the edges of my power. That could not be allowed. Better to cull the herd, leave only the strongest..."

He reached out with fingers that were also galaxies, also swords, also the hands of Nanzo's dead father.

"...and guide the survivor to his true purpose."

The golden sea transformed.

Suddenly they stood in a garden—if gardens were made of floating continents and trees that bore fruit of compressed starlight. Nanzo recognized it from the clan's most forbidden texts: The Divine Tree Orchard, where Ōtsutsuki gods cultivated chakra fruit from devoured worlds.

Other figures materialized in the distance—Isshiki, Kaguya, Momoshiki, Kinshiki, Urashiki—all the Ōtsutsuki who had descended upon the ninja world throughout history. They were silhouettes, watching, waiting.

"The harvest approaches," Shibai said. "This world—your precious 'Earth'—ripens. Kaguya's betrayal delayed it, but the fruit will be ready within your lifetime."

He turned fully to Nanzo, and for a moment, he had a face—Nanzo's own face, but perfected, immortal, crowned with horns of pure chakra.

"Join us."

The offer resonated through every layer of Nanzo's being.

"Abandon this fragile mortal shell. I will remake you as my successor—a true Ōtsutsuki, not merely a diluted descendant. You will have immortality. You will drink the chakra fruit's nectar and transcend death itself. Your Wave Style will become Divine Wave Style—capable of shattering dimensions, not merely organs."

Shibai's eyes—now fully Rinnegan, now Byakugan, now something beyond both—burned with terrible promise.

"In return, you will help us harvest. You will identify the strongest chakra signatures on Earth—the jinchūriki, the Kage, the kekkei genkai masters. You will prepare them for consumption. And when the Divine Tree blooms..."

He extended his hand.

"...you will be there to eat first."

Nanzo looked at the hand that had orchestrated his parents' murder.

He looked at the face that wore his own features like a mask.

He looked at the "god" who had reduced his mother's sacrifice to "delicious waste."

And he laughed.

It started as a chuckle—disbelieving, bitter. It grew into full-throated, hysterical laughter that made the golden sea churn and the Divine Tree Orchard tremble. Nanzo laughed until his dream-form flickered, until tears that weren't real streamed down his face, until Shibai's expression shifted from confidence to confusion to cold, ancient rage.

"You... find this amusing?" The god's voice was the pressure of collapsing stars.

"Amusing?" Nanzo gasped, wiping phantom tears. "No. Pathetic. You're pathetic."

He stepped forward, dream-form solidifying with sheer force of will, and spat at Shibai's feet—the golden sand of this divine realm hissing where his contempt landed.

"You think I want your immortality? Your 'Divine Wave Style'? I've seen what godhood does to your kind. Kaguya went mad. Isshiki became a parasite. Momoshiki was so desperate for power he ate his own partner."

He circled the god now, his voice dropping to a snarl that would have done his wife proud.

"You abandoned your body to become... this." He gestured at Shibai's shifting, formless presence. "Pure chakra? Pure will? You're nothing. You're a ghost haunting your own descendants, too cowardly to die, too weak to truly live. You whisper in dreams because you can't walk in reality. You 'encourage' massacres because you're impotent to act directly."

Shibai's form darkened. The golden sea turned black. The distant Ōtsutsuki silhouettes began to move closer, sensing their progenitor's fury.

"You know what I think of when I wake up screaming?" Nanzo pressed, relentless. "Not you. Not your 'divine' power. I think of my mother burning to save me. I think of my father's last breath. I think of Nora—eight years old—holding my baby self while her entire family died around her."

He leaned into Shibai's darkness, unafraid.

"They gave me mortality, you cosmic parasite. They gave me limits, and pain, and love—real love, not this... this consumption you call godhood. My wife bites my neck and I feel alive. You haven't felt anything in millennia."

The god's rage was now a physical force, crushing, suffocating.

"You DARE—"

"I DARE." Nanzo shouted back, his Wave Style resonance finally manifesting in this dream-realm— golden ripples of defiant chakra pushing back against Shibai's darkness. "I am Nanzo Anitsu! Last heir of a clan YOU murdered! Husband to the woman who defeated me! Master of Wave Style, Wind Style, Gravity Manipulation—techniques I BUILT with physics and pain and choice!"

He straightened, and for a moment, he was more solid than the god before him.

"I don't need your immortality. I don't want your successorship. I would rather die in thirty minutes using Waver Mode to protect my wife than live forever as your appetite."

Shibai was silent.

Then, slowly, the darkness receded—but not in defeat. In promise.

"You refuse." It was not a question.

"Obviously."

"You mock me."

"Thoroughly."

Shibai's form condensed into something almost human—beautiful, terrible, smiling.

"Then remember this, little wave:" The god's voice dropped to a whisper that would echo in Nanzo's skull for the rest of his life. "When the harvest comes. When your precious wife's chakra ripens. When this world burns and the fruit is plucked..."

He leaned close, breath that smelled of dead worlds and aborted futures.

"...I will come for you."

The smile widened, showing teeth that were also tombstones, also the shards of the moon.

"And you will watch me consume everything you love, descendant. You will watch because I will make you last. I will make you taste immortality as the sole survivor—again—before I unmake your very concept."

Nanzo felt himself being ejected—the dream-realm rejecting his defiance, Shibai's will thrusting him back toward consciousness.

"Sleep well, Nanzo Anitsu," the god's voice followed him through the void. "Dream of waves. Dream of your mother's burning. Dream of me."

The Waking

Nanzo jolted awake.

His own gasp was loud in the dark bedroom. He was drenched in sweat, his black wolf-hair plastered to his forehead, his yellow eyes wide and unseeing. His heart hammered against his ribs like it wanted to escape.

For a terrible moment, he could still feel Shibai's presence—could still smell the ozone-and-rot scent of the Ōtsutsuki realm. His left hand went instinctively to his neck, to the bite scar Karui had left there, grounding himself in physical reality.

"Nanzo?"

Karui's voice—sleep-rough, concerned—cut through the lingering terror like a blade through silk.

She was already sitting up, amber eyes alert despite having been deeply asleep moments before. Jonin reflexes. Killer B's training. Her hand was on the sword she kept beneath her pillow, but her eyes were scanning him—checking for injury, for Genjutsu, for threat.

"What happened?" she demanded. "You're shaking. Your chakra... it feels wrong. Like it's still vibrating at some frequency I can't hear."

Nanzo opened his mouth.

Shibai Ōtsutsuki contacted me. The god of our clan's secret bloodline. He offered me immortality. I refused. He threatened to destroy everything I love. He'll come for us. For you.

He looked at his wife—his wife, dark and beautiful and alive, wearing one of his oversized shirts to bed, her red hair mussed

from sleep, her wrist tattoo of his face catching the moonlight.

He thought of Shibai's promise: "When your precious wife's chakra ripens."

He thought of her Final Resonance—burning herself to protect what she loved.

"Nothing," he said.

The lie tasted like ash, but it tasted better than fear.

Karui's eyes narrowed. She knew him too well—knew every micro-expression, every tells from their years of sparring, their marriage, their bond. She knew he was lying.

But she also knew he would tell her when he was ready. Or when he needed to.

She reached out, her dark hand finding his pale one in the darkness, intertwining their fingers. Her thumb traced the back of his hand—a gesture of comfort, of presence, of I am here and I am real and I am not going anywhere.

"Nothing," she repeated, not believing him for a second, but accepting the lie for now.

She pulled him back down to the mattress, arranging them so that his head rested on her chest—close enough to hear her heartbeat, to feel her warmth, to smell the scent he had once called his addiction.

"Sleep," she commanded softly, her hand in his hair. "Whatever it was, it can't have you tonight. I won't let it."

Nanzo closed his eyes.

In the darkness behind his lids, Shibai's final whisper still echoed: "I will come for you."

But here, in the warmth of his wife's arms, with her heartbeat a steady drum against his ear and her sword within arm's reach, Nanzo found the strength to whisper back—if only to himself:

"Let him come."

He pressed closer to Karui, breathing in her scent—life, mortality, love—and finally, fitfully, slept.

Chapter 9: The Mission to the Land of Waves

The assignment came through standard channels: investigate disturbances in the Land of Waves, a small nation that had once been oppressed by the criminal Gatō but had since become a peaceful ally of the Hidden Leaf. Now, something was disrupting their shipping lanes, sinking vessels without trace, leaving no survivors.

Darui assigned the mission to Team Samui, with Nanzo attached as a specialist consultant. It was the first time Karui would work with her old team since her marriage, and she felt the complexity of the situation as they gathered at the village gates.

Samui looked the same—cool, professional, her blonde hair immaculate. Omoi looked different, somehow older, his worried expression replaced by something more settled. And Nanzo...

Nanzo wore his formal mission gear, the white armor of the Anitsu Clan adapted for travel, his sword at his hip. He looked every inch the clan head, the powerful shinobi, the man who had grown beyond the Prince she had first defeated.

"Newlyweds on a mission together," Omoi said, his tone carefully neutral. "This should be interesting. Or disastrous. Or interestingly disastrous."

"Shut up, Omoi," Karui said, but without heat. She was too focused on the mission, on the reports of wave-based attacks that had drawn Darui's attention and Nanzo's concern.

"The Land of Waves," Nanzo said, studying the map. "Appropriately named. If our theoretical enemy is using wave-techniques, this environment would amplify their power significantly."

"Or yours," Samui noted. "Your clan's abilities are wave-based as well, aren't they?"

"Similar but distinct." Nanzo rolled the map, his expression serious. "Which is why I'm concerned. If someone has developed

a technique that mimics our style, they could be using the ocean itself as a weapon. That level of destruction would be... catastrophic."

They traveled in silence for the first day, moving through the forests that separated Lightning from Water territories. Karui walked beside Nanzo, close enough to support him if needed, far enough to maintain professional distance in front of her team. It was a balance they were still learning.

That night, around the campfire, Omoi finally broke the tension.

"So," he said, roasting a fish on a stick with more attention than the task required. "Marriage. How's that working out for you two?"

"Omoi," Samui warned.

"What? I'm curious! It's not every day your teammate marries the most powerful clan head in the village. I have questions." He looked at Nanzo. "Does she still call you Prince?"

Nanzo smiled, the expression transforming his face from intimidating to approachable. "Only when she's annoyed with me. Which is frequently."

"And you let her?"

"I encourage it." Nanzo's eyes found Karui across the fire, warm with private memory. "It reminds me of who I was, who I am, who I want to be. She keeps me honest, Omoi-san. No one else in my life does that."

Karui felt her cheeks warm, grateful for the darkness that hid her blush. "He's not so bad himself," she muttered. "For a Prince."

They laughed, the sound easing the tension, and for a moment they were just four shinobi on a mission, partners in danger, bound by trust rather than blood or law.

Then the wave hit.

It came without warning—a wall of water rising from the nearby river, shaped into a hand that reached for them with unmistakable malice. Nanzo moved first, his hands forming seals

that Karui didn't recognize, creating a counter-wave that met the attack and dispersed it into harmless spray.

"Up!" he shouted. "Into the trees! It's coming from the water!"

They scrambled upward, finding perches in the high branches, scanning the darkness for their attacker. The river below churned, foam rising, and from its depths emerged a figure wrapped in seals and bandages, their chakra signature distorted beyond recognition.

"Anitsu," the figure said, their voice bubbling like water through a drowning throat. "We have waited for you. The heir of Shibai. The last carrier of true wave."

"Who are you?" Nanzo demanded, his hands ready with seals.

"We are the Tide," the figure replied. "The ones who were forgotten when your ancestor ascended. We who were left behind to drown in mortal flesh while Shibai transcended. And we have come to claim what was promised—your blood, your power, your life as sacrifice to open the path."

The figure raised their hands, and the river responded, rising into serpents of water that struck at the trees with crushing force. Nanzo countered with Wave Style, his own vibrations disrupting the water's cohesion, but Karui saw the strain on his face—this enemy was strong, their technique refined in ways that suggested years of dedicated practice.

"Karui!" Nanzo called. "The seals on their chest! They're using stored chakra to amplify the waves—if you can break the containment, you'll disrupt their power!"

"On it!" She leaped from her branch, sword drawn, using the techniques she had taught him and he had enhanced with physics—calculating angles, using momentum, turning her body into a projectile that closed the distance before the water-serpents could intercept.

The Tide-figure saw her coming and laughed, a gurgling sound. "The dark wife! The pollution of purity! You think your steel can harm one who commands the ocean itself?"

"My steel," Karui grunted, parrying a water-whip, "is the least of your worries."

She struck, not at the figure but at the riverbank beneath them, her chakra-enhanced blade cutting through stone and earth, destabilizing the ground that supported their position. The figure stumbled, their concentration breaking for just a moment—and in that moment, Nanzo struck.

Wave Style: Internal Resonance. A precise frequency that bypassed the water defenses and struck directly at the seal-containment on the figure's chest. There was a sound like breaking glass, and the stored chakra erupted outward, throwing both combatants back.

Karui hit a tree, the impact driving breath from her lungs, but she forced herself up, searching for Nanzo. She found him in the river shallows, his white armor stained with mud, his hand extended toward the collapsing figure of their enemy.

"Who sent you?" he demanded, his voice carrying the weight of clan head authority. "Who else knows the secret of Shibai?"

The figure laughed, blood bubbling from beneath their bandages. "Everyone... will know... soon. The Tide rises... Anitsu. You cannot stop... the return. Your wife... your dark wife... will be the first to drown... in the wave of your... ascension..."

They dissolved then, becoming water, becoming nothing, leaving only wet bandages and the echo of their threat.

Karui stumbled to Nanzo's side, checking him for injuries, her hands shaking with adrenaline and fear. "What did they mean? Ascending? Drowning?"

"I don't know." He stared at the empty bandages, his expression haunted. "But I intend to find out. The Tide... they're connected to Shibai's original followers. The ones who were left behind when my ancestor transcended. If they're seeking revenge, seeking to force ascension through sacrifice..." He looked at her, and she saw the fear in his eyes. "They want me to use the Waver Mode, Karui. They want me to burn out, to become like Shibai, to leave this world behind. And they think that threatening you is the way to force that choice."

"Then we stop them." She helped him stand, her grip firm on his arm. "Together. Before they can force anything."

"Together," he agreed. But his eyes remained on the water, where the bandages floated like a warning, and she knew he was thinking of the chamber deep beneath the compound, and the power that could save everything at the cost of his life.

Chapter 10: The Tide Rises

The investigation led them to the Land of Waves' coast, to a village that had been abandoned for years, ever since Gatō's reign of terror. Now it was occupied again, but not by living people. The buildings were filled with water, shaped into forms that mimicked human habitation—tables of ice, chairs of compressed liquid, curtains of falling spray that somehow maintained their form against gravity.

"The Tide's sanctuary," Samui observed, her voice low. "They've transformed the entire village into a temple of water."

"It's beautiful," Omoi said, and he wasn't wrong. In the moonlight, the water-structures glowed with an ethereal light, blue and green and silver. "And completely terrifying."

Nanzo moved through the streets with the confidence of someone who understood what they were seeing. "Wave resonance," he explained, touching a pillar of spinning water that hummed beneath his fingers. "They're using the same principles as my clan, but applied externally rather than internally. Instead of manipulating their own chakra waves, they're manipulating the waves in the environment. It's less powerful but more versatile."

"Can you counter it?" Karui asked.

"Yes. But not without significant destruction." He looked at the water-structures, at the artistry and the madness combined. "If I use my full power here, I'll destroy the entire village. And possibly trigger geological instability that could affect the whole region."

"Then we do this quietly," Samui decided. "Infiltration, not assault. Find their leader, learn their plans, disrupt their operations with minimal collateral damage."

"Agreed." Nanzo looked at Karui, a question in his eyes. "Can you handle close combat in a water-rich environment? Your lightning techniques..."

"Will be less effective, yes. But I'm not just lightning." She drew her sword, feeling the balance of it, the weight that had become familiar as her own arm. "I'm the woman who defeated you in a forest, remember? I don't need elemental advantages to be dangerous."

He smiled, that rare expression that made her heart stutter. "I remember. I will always remember."

They split up, Samui and Omoi taking the northern sector while Karui and Nanzo moved toward the central structure—a temple of water that rose higher than the surrounding buildings, its spires reaching toward the moon like grasping fingers.

The interior was a maze of liquid walls and floors that solidified only when stepped upon. Karui moved carefully, her chakra control precise, maintaining her balance on surfaces that shifted and flowed. Nanzo walked beside her with easier confidence, his Wave Style allowing him to sense the stability of each step before he took it.

"They know we're here," he murmured, his hand brushing hers in the darkness. "The water is responding to our presence, carrying information to the center."

"Then let's not keep them waiting."

They emerged into a central chamber, a cathedral of water where the moonlight streamed through a ceiling of liquid glass, casting everything in shifting blue light. And at the center, waiting for them, was a figure that made Nanzo stop short.

She was old, older than Nora, her skin wrinkled and pale, her eyes—not yellow, but blue, the color of deep water—fixed on them with an expression of terrible recognition.

"Nanzo," she said, her voice carrying the weight of tides. "Grandson of my sister. Last heir of the line that abandoned us."

"Grandson?" Karui looked at Nanzo, saw the shock on his face.

"My father's sister," he whispered. "She was reported killed in the Second War. We thought... the entire branch family was thought destroyed."

"Not destroyed," the old woman said. "Transformed. We who were left behind when Shibai called the worthy—we found another path. The path of the Tide, of eternal becoming, of water that never dies but only changes form." She raised her hands, and the chamber responded, walls becoming waves that crashed and reformed in endless cycle. "I am Umi, first of the Tide, and I have waited sixty years to complete what was begun. To force the ascension. To make one of our blood transcend, as Shibai did, and open the path for all of us."

"You want me to use the Waver Mode," Nanzo said. "To burn out my life and become like Shibai."

"I want you to fulfill your destiny!" Umi's voice rose, the water responding to her emotion, becoming storm. "Your line has hoarded the power for generations, using it for petty human concerns while the true purpose was forgotten! Shibai left us behind, trapped in flesh, and only another ascension can reopen the door! Your death will save thousands, will allow us all to transcend, to become wave and water and eternal!"

"And if I refuse?"

Umi's eyes moved to Karui, and her expression became something cold and calculating. "Then the dark wife dies. Slowly. Drowned and revived and drowned again, until your heart breaks and you embrace the power in your grief. We have studied you, Nanzo. We know that she is your weakness, your anchor to mortality. Without her, you would ascend willingly, joyfully, to join her in the next form of existence."

Karui felt ice in her veins, but she didn't show fear. Instead, she stepped forward, placing herself between Umi and Nanzo, her sword raised. "You think you know him," she said, her voice

steady. "You think you know what he'll do for love. But you don't know us. You don't know what we've built together."

"I know that love is a chain," Umi replied. "A weight that holds us down from our true potential. When she dies, you will see. You will thank me for freeing you."

The water attacked.

Not as simple waves, but as shapes—hands and teeth and crushing pressure, coming from all directions at once. Nanzo responded with Wave Style, creating counter-frequencies that disrupted the water's cohesion, but Umi was powerful, her connection to this place giving her advantages that even his clan techniques couldn't fully counter.

Karui fought beside him, her sword cutting through water-forms that reformed instantly, her body moving in the patterns she had taught him and they had refined together. But it wasn't enough. The Tide had prepared for this, had shaped this battlefield specifically to neutralize their strengths.

"Nanzo!" she called, parrying a water-spear. "We need to retreat, regroup!"

"We can't." He was breathing hard, his chakra reserves depleting rapidly. "If we leave, she'll follow. She'll strike at the village, at Nora, at anyone I care about. This ends here."

"Then end it!" She grabbed his arm, forcing him to look at her. "Use what you need to use. I trust you."

"I can't!" The desperation in his voice broke her heart. "If I use the Waver Mode, I die. And I promised you—I promised I wouldn't leave you. I won't break that promise, Karui. Not even to win."

Umi laughed, the sound echoing through the water-cathedral. "Noble! Foolish! You would let her die to keep your word? What kind of love is that?"

"The kind that trusts," Karui said. She turned to face Umi, her sword dropping to her side, her stance opening in apparent surrender. "You want him to ascend? You think that will save you? You're wrong. Shibai didn't ascend through power. He

ascended through understanding. Through letting go of everything that tied him to this world—including the desire to transcend."

"Philosophy!" Umi sneered. "Words to comfort the weak!"

"Truth to challenge the strong." Karui moved forward, walking through the water that should have drowned her, feeling Nanzo's Wave Style creating pockets of air, of safety, of possibility. "You want to force ascension? You can't. It has to be chosen. Freely. With full understanding of what is being left behind."

She reached Umi, close enough to strike, close enough to be struck. The old woman's eyes widened, surprised by her audacity.

"Kill me," Karui said, "and he will never ascend. He will destroy himself trying to avenge me, or he will live broken, or he will find another way to stop you. But he will not become what you want. Because love isn't a chain, Umi. It's a choice. Every day, choosing to stay, to grow, to be human. And that choice is stronger than your water, stronger than your waves, stronger than your desperate fear of death."

Umi stared at her, and in the blue eyes, Karui saw something shift. Doubt. Recognition. The first crack in sixty years of certainty.

"You... you truly believe this," Umi whispered.

"I truly live it." Karui held out her hand, not as a fighter but as a fellow human being. "Come back with us. Let us help you find another way. Your family—Nanzo's family—thought you were dead. They mourned you. They don't have to lose you again."

For a moment, impossibly, Umi hesitated. The water around them calmed, the storm pausing, possibility hanging in the balance.

Then the seal on Umi's chest—the same type that Nanzo had identified on the earlier attacker—began to glow red. Her eyes widened in terror.

"No," she gasped. "I didn't... I didn't trigger it..."

"Umi!" Nanzo lunged forward, his hands forming seals, trying to disrupt whatever was happening. But he was too late, too depleted, too slow.

The seal exploded.

Not with fire, but with water—pure, concentrated, pressurized water that expanded instantly to fill the chamber. Karui felt herself lifted, thrown, the breath crushed from her lungs by the sudden pressure.

She saw Nanzo reaching for her, his mouth open in a scream she couldn't hear, his yellow eyes wide with horror.

Then the water closed over her head, and everything went dark.

Chapter 11: The Drowning and the Rescue

Consciousness returned slowly, accompanied by pain and the desperate need to breathe. Karui coughed, water pouring from her lungs, her body convulsing as it fought to clear itself of liquid death.

"Stay with me," Nanzo's voice, raw and terrified. "Karui, stay with me. Breathe. Just breathe."

She opened her eyes to see him above her, his white armor gone, his pale skin covered in cuts and bruises, his hands pressing rhythmically on her chest. They were on the shore somewhere, the moon still high, the water lapping gently at their feet. The water-cathedral was gone, collapsed into the sea, leaving only wet sand and debris.

"Umi?" she managed, her voice a rasp.

"Gone. The seal was a failsafe—triggered remotely when she hesitated. Whoever controls the Tide didn't want her to be reasoned with." Nanzo's hands moved to her face, cradling it with desperate gentleness. "I thought I lost you. The pressure, the water, I couldn't reach you in time. If Samui and Omoi hadn't

arrived when they did..."

"Samui?" Karui turned her head, saw her teammates approaching across the beach, their own gear damaged, their expressions grim.

"We found their secondary base," Samui reported. "A command center. Whoever is leading the Tide wasn't here—they're operating remotely, through seals and proxies. But we found intelligence. Names, locations, their broader plan."

"They're targeting all the hidden villages," Omoi added, his usual worry replaced by something harder. "Not just Kumogakure. They have agents everywhere, waiting to trigger wave-based catastrophes. Tsunamis, earthquakes, chakra network disruptions. They want to force ascension on a global scale— kill enough people, cause enough destruction, that someone somewhere will embrace the Waver Mode out of desperation."

"And open the path for all of them to transcend," Nanzo finished, his voice hollow. "A apocalypse of waves, designed to create a god."

Karui forced herself to sit up, her body protesting every movement. "Then we stop them. We find their leader, we disrupt their network, we prevent any of this from happening."

"How?" Nanzo asked. "They're everywhere and nowhere. We don't even know who the true leader is."

"We know they're afraid of reason." Karui grabbed his hand, squeezing it with what strength she had. "Umi hesitated when I spoke to her. She was ready to listen, to change, before the seal killed her. That means the Tide's ideology isn't as solid as they want us to believe. There are cracks. Doubts. We find those cracks and we widen them."

"Divide and conquer," Samui said, nodding slowly. "Turn their own members against them."

"While we hunt their leadership," Omoi added. "Cut off the head, and the body dies."

Nanzo was silent for a long moment, staring at the ocean where his great-aunt had died. Then he nodded, his expression hardening into resolve. "We return to Kumogakure. We brief Darui, we mobilize our network, we begin systematic disruption of Tide operations worldwide. And we find their leader—whoever is pulling the strings, triggering the seals, forcing good people like Umi to die rather than think for themselves."

He helped Karui stand, supporting her weight when her legs threatened to give out. "Are you alright?" he asked softly, for her ears only.

"I will be." She leaned into him, accepting his strength, offering her own in return. "But Nanzo—promise me again. No matter what they do, no matter how bad it gets, no Waver Mode. We find another way. Together."

"I promise," he said. And this time, she believed him.

VOLUME III: THE WAVER'S CHOICE

Chapter 12: The War of Waves

Six months. Six months of covert operations, of hunting Tide cells across the elemental nations, of disrupting their plans and saving their potential victims. Six months of partnership tested in fire, of love growing stronger with each challenge overcome.

Now they stood on the cliffs above Kumogakure, watching the storm gather on the horizon. The Tide's final gambit. Their leader had been identified—a man named Kaiyō, once a scholar of the Hidden Mist, now obsessed with achieving what Umi had failed to force. He had spent decades studying Shibai's legacy, and he believed he had found a way to trigger mass ascension without needing a willing sacrifice.

He needed only a focal point. A nexus of wave energy that could amplify his technique across the entire world.

He needed Nanzo.

"He's coming here," Darui said, his Black Lightning crackling with suppressed tension. "Our intelligence confirms it. He believes that if he can force Nanzo into Waver Mode near the village, the resonance will trigger a chain reaction. Every hidden village will experience wave-catastrophe simultaneously. Millions will die. And in the chaos, someone—perhaps multiple someones—will embrace ascension out of desperation."

"Then we evacuate," Karui said. "Get everyone out of range."

"Two hundred kilometers," Nanzo whispered. "That's the Waver Mode's range. We can't evacuate the entire continent."

"Then we stop him before he can force your hand." Karui turned to face her husband, her partner, her love. "We fight him here, on our terms. And we win without the Waver Mode."

"How?" Nanzo's voice was bleak. "He's studied my techniques. He knows my weaknesses. He'll exploit the five-meter dead zone, force me into close combat where I'm vulnerable, make me choose between death and ascension."

"Then we don't give him the choice." Karui stepped closer, her hands on his shoulders, her eyes locked on his. "We fight together. You and me. Long range and close. Wave and steel. We show him what partnership really means."

The storm hit at dawn.

Kaiyō came walking across the water, the ocean itself parting before him, his body wrapped in seals that glowed with sickly green light. He was younger than they expected, his face unlined, his eyes—the blue of deep water, like Umi's—bright with fanatical certainty.

"Nanzo Anitsu," he called, his voice carrying across the waves. "I offer you a choice. Ascend willingly, become the god you were born to be, and save those you love. Or resist, and watch me destroy everything you care about until you have no choice left."

"There's always a choice," Nanzo replied, his own voice amplified by Wave Style resonance. "You just don't like the ones that don't end with you getting what you want."

Kaiyō smiled, and the water rose behind him, forming into shapes—giants, monsters, the entire ocean become an army. "Then let me narrow your options."

The battle was unlike anything Karui had experienced. Kaiyō didn't fight directly; he commanded the environment, turning the sea itself into a weapon that struck from all directions at once. Nanzo countered with Wave Style, disrupting the water's coherence, creating zones of stability in the chaos, but it was a losing proposition. For every wave he stopped, three more rose. For every attack he deflected, Kaiyō simply reshaped the water and struck again.

Karui fought through it, her sword cutting through water-forms, her body moving in the patterns she had taught Nanzo, the partnership that made them stronger than either alone. But she couldn't reach Kaiyō. He stayed safely distant, beyond her sword's reach, beyond even Nanzo's optimal gravity range.

"He's wearing you down," she called to Nanzo, parrying a water-spear. "Forcing you to expend chakra until you're desperate."

"I know." He was breathing hard, his white armor stained with salt and blood. "He's trying to make me use the Waver Mode. He thinks that if he pushes me hard enough, I'll choose ascension just to stop him."

"Will you?"

He looked at her, and she saw the exhaustion in his eyes, the temptation, the desperate calculation of whether thirty minutes of godhood might be worth the price.

"No," he said. "I promised. I promised you."

"Then trust me." She sheathed her sword, a gesture that made Kaiyō pause, that made Nanzo stare. "Trust me, and do exactly what I say."

She explained quickly, her voice low, her plan desperate and dangerous and possibly suicidal. But Nanzo listened, and his eyes lit with understanding, and when she finished, he kissed her—hard, brief, a promise and a farewell in one.

"Together," he said.

"Together," she agreed.

She ran.

Not away, but toward Kaiyō, sprinting across the water's surface with chakra-enhanced speed, closing the distance that had kept her from him. Kaiyō laughed, raising his hands to summon a wall of water that would crush her, that would end this annoying gnat who thought she could challenge a god.

But Nanzo moved too.

Gravity Manipulation. The technique he had created, unique to him, that could lock even gods in place. He activated it at maximum range, catching Kaiyō in the field, freezing him for one precious minute.

One minute. Sixty seconds. The same duration that had doomed him in the forest, all those years ago.

Kaiyō laughed, even as he couldn't move. "Fool! You know what this costs you! Thirty-minute cooldown, no gravity, no wave style for fifteen minutes! You'll be helpless!"

"I know," Nanzo said. He was running too, following Karui, closing the distance to his own dead zone. "But I'm not helpless. I haven't been helpless for a long time."

Karui reached Kaiyō as the gravity field released. The water wall collapsed without his direction, becoming simple ocean again. She was inside his guard, inside the space where he had thought himself safe, and her sword was already moving.

He tried to counter with water, with wave techniques, but she was too close, too fast, too well-trained by the woman who had defeated the most powerful clan head in Kumogakure. Her blade struck the seals on his chest—not to kill, but to disrupt, to destroy the containment that allowed him to command the ocean.

"No!" Kaiyō screamed as his power unraveled. "You can't! I am the Tide! I am the future!"

"You're a man who forgot how to be human," Karui said, her sword at his throat. "And I'm the woman who remembers."

Nanzo reached them then, entering the five-meter zone where his long-range techniques were useless, where he had once been completely vulnerable. But he wasn't vulnerable anymore. He had trained for this. He had prepared.

Close combat. Taijutsu. The sword techniques that Karui had taught him, enhanced by his understanding of physics and force. He struck Kaiyō precisely, scientifically, targeting nerve clusters and pressure points with a precision that no pure warrior could match.

Kaiyō fell, his power broken, his army of water collapsing back into the ocean, the storm dissipating as suddenly as it had come.

They stood over him, dark and pale, stubborn and scientific, partners in truth.

"You could kill me," Kaiyō gasped, blood mixing with salt water on his lips. "End the threat."

"We could," Nanzo agreed. "But that would make us like you. Believing that ends justify means, that power is the only solution." He knelt, placing a seal on Kaiyō's forehead that would suppress his chakra, render him harmless. "You're going to live. You're going to face judgment for your crimes. And maybe, in time, you'll learn what Umi almost learned—that ascension isn't something you force. It's something you earn, through living fully, through loving deeply, through choosing humanity over godhood every single day."

Karui helped him stand, their hands finding each other automatically. "We did it," she said, wonderingly. "Without the Waver Mode. Without anyone dying."

"We did it," he agreed. "Together."

Behind them, the sun broke through the clouds, illuminating Kumogakure and the ocean beyond. The Tide was defeated. The threat was ended. And they were still alive, still human, still choosing each other against all the forces that wanted to tear them apart.

Chapter 13: "The Gravity of Wolves"

The morning mist clung to the Anitsu Clan compound like a shroud, curling around the ancient stone walls that had survived the Second Great Ninja War. Nanzo stood at the eastern gate, his travel pack light, his expression carefully neutral. At twenty years old, he carried the weight of a clan that had been reduced to five living souls, a Kekkei Genkai that could liquefy organs with a thought, and a secret so terrible that only his wife knew its full measure.

"You're certain about this?" Karui asked.

She stood close enough that he could smell her—dark skin warmed by the morning sun, the faint metallic tang of the sword oil she used on her katana, something uniquely her that he had once described, privately, as his addiction. Her amber eyes caught the light, sharp and searching. Not yellow like his. Not pure like the blood descendants of his clan. Beautiful precisely because they were different.

"It's not a messenger mission," Nanzo said, adjusting his forehead protector. He no longer wore the Kumogakure band—his status as clan head superseded such identifiers—but he carried it in his pack. A formality for crossing borders. "The Raikage requested someone of appropriate rank to discuss Chūnin Exam coordination with Konohagakure. Given my... unique position."

"Unique position." Karui's voice was dry. "You mean the fact that you're beyond Kage-level and could theoretically destroy their entire village if they annoy you?"

"I mean the fact that I'm clan head and therefore politically relevant." He reached out, his pale fingers tracing the line of her jaw, feeling the warmth there. The contrast that Nora Anitsu—waiting somewhere inside the compound, maintaining perfect surface politeness—found so disturbing. "And yes. That."

Karui caught his hand, her grip strong. The grip of a woman who had bitten his neck while he was helpless, who had trained him to wield a blade when his long-range techniques failed, who

wore his face tattooed on her wrist as permanent declaration.

"You're bored," she said. It wasn't an accusation. It was understanding. "Curious. You want to see the world beyond Cloud's borders."

"I want to see if they measure up," he admitted, smiling slightly. "To you. To this." He gestured vaguely at the compound, at the life they had built together—him, the orphan raised by a maid he called "Mom" in private, married to the woman who had defeated him through sheer stubborn refusal to die.

Karui's expression softened in a way that only he ever saw. The fierce, combative kunoichi who had beaten Naruto Uzumaki bloody, who had faced down Sasuke's crimes with fists instead of words, who carried the "ugly dark" label from the insecure some of the older clans as a badge of defiant pride—she softened for him.

"Come back," she said simply. "I don't care if you learn their secrets. I don't care if you fight their Kage. Just come back."

"I will," he promised. And because Nora was watching from a window, maintaining the fiction of distance, he added formally: "Take care of the compound, Nora-san. I'll return within the week."

"Travel safely, Nanzo-sama," came the proper response.

But Karui saw the way his eyes lingered, the subtle warmth that spoke of private moments—of him calling that woman "Mom," of kissing her cheek in gratitude for raising him, of the complex bond between a boy who had lost everything and the woman who had given him back his future. Karui understood it. Respected it, even, though she knew what Nora truly thought when she looked at her daughter-in-law.

Ugly dark. Dark lips. Ugly body shape. Someone who might scare him if he truly saw her clearly.

Let her think it. Karui was the village majority in this village. The Raikage was dark. Killer B was dark. Darui was dark. She was the standard, not the exception. The some of the older clans's discomfort was their own weakness.

"White is ugly," Karui murmured, too quietly for anyone but Nanzo to hear. "Dark is beautiful and sexy."

He laughed, pressing his forehead to hers. "And I am the luckiest man in any village, because I know it's true."

Then he was gone, moving with the casual speed of someone who could, if he chose, cross the distance between villages in minutes rather than days. But he took his time. A journey, not a mission. A chance to breathe air that didn't carry the weight of his clan's extinction, his parents' death in the Second War, the burden of being the only one who knew about Shibai Ōtsutsuki.

The wind carried him southeast, toward the Land of Fire.

Konohagakure was... green.

Nanzo had prepared himself for the difference—Kumogakure sat high in the mountains, all stone and lightning and thin air, while the Hidden Leaf nestled in a forest basin, lush and sprawling. But preparation was not experience. He found himself lingering at the gates longer than necessary, watching the flow of people, noting the demographic balance that was so different from his home.

Here, the majority of Cloud was not present. Here, he was not the statistical minority, the rare "Prince" prized for his pale skin and yellow eyes. Here, he was simply... foreign. Powerful, certainly—the guards at the gate had sensed that immediately, their hands drifting toward weapons before discipline reasserted itself. But not rare.

It was oddly liberating.

His meeting with Kakashi Hatake was scheduled for the following morning. Official business. Chūnin Exam coordination, joint training exercises, the endless diplomacy of villages pretending they weren't measuring each other for weaknesses. Nanzo could have handled it in an hour and returned home.

Instead, he checked into a guest house near the village center, deposited his pack, and went walking.

The Inuzuka compound lay northwest of the main village, separated from the Aburame clan by training grounds and forest

buffer. Nanzo found it by following his nose—the distinct scent of canines, of wildness, of a clan that refused full domestication. The compound itself was low-slung and practical, designed for beings with four legs as much as two.

He was watching a young boy—Kiba, he would later learn—training with a puppy when she found him.

"You're trespassing."

The voice came from above. Nanzo looked up, his yellow eyes tracking the figure perched on a branch fifteen feet overhead. She was... feral. That was the word that came to mind. Long brown hair pulled back in a spiky tail, vertical slit pupils that marked her Inuzuka blood, red fang tattoos carved into her cheeks. She wore a standard flak jacket over a cropped top, her midriff exposed, her posture that of a predator measuring prey.

"Nanzo Anitsu," he said, offering a slight bow. "From Kumogakure. I apologize—I was curious about your compound's architecture. The way you've integrated living spaces with kennel facilities is... efficient."

She dropped from the branch, landing without sound. A large black hound emerged from the shadows beside her, hackles rising, intelligent eyes fixed on the intruder.

"Architecture," the woman repeated, her voice rich with skepticism. "You're the Cloud Prince. The white-skinned miracle from the minority clan. Married to that red-haired berserker who beat the hell out of Naruto Uzumaki during the Summit."

Nanzo felt his eyebrows rise. "You know of my wife?"

"Know of her?" The woman laughed, sharp and barking. "Tsume Inuzuka. Tokubetsu jōnin. I was at the Summit, standing guard. Saw your girl work. Fierce. Stubborn." Tsume's eyes narrowed, her nose twitching. "She smells like you. Deeply. Permanently. You wear each other like armor."

"We're married," Nanzo said simply.

"Obviously." Tsume circled him, and he let her, standing still as her hound—Kuromaru, he would learn—growled low in his throat. "So what does a beyond-Kage-level shinobi want in my

woods, Anitsu? Because you reek of power. Wave chakra, wind manipulation, something else—gravity? You're a walking natural disaster wearing human skin."

Nanzo considered lying. Considered the diplomatic response, the careful deflection. Instead, he found himself telling the truth.

"I'm bored," he said. "And curious. And I have three days before my official business requires me to return home. I thought... perhaps... someone here might spar with me. Someone who wouldn't hold back because of my rank."

Tsume stopped circling. Her slit pupils dilated slightly, and he realized she was scenting him—not just his chakra, but his emotional state. The loneliness he carried. The weight of being the last hope of a nearly extinct clan. The desperate, consuming love he felt for the woman who had defeated him.

"You want to fight," she said slowly. "Not to win. Just to... move."

"Yes."

She studied him for a long moment. Then she smiled, all teeth, wild and dangerous.

"Tomorrow. Dawn. The training grounds behind the compound. Bring your sword—I've heard you learned kenjutsu from your wife. I want to see if the rumors are true."

She turned and walked away, her hound following, leaving Nanzo standing in the gathering dusk with his heart beating faster than it had in months.

They met as promised, and Tsume Inuzuka did not hold back.

She came at him with the Fang Passing Fang, her body rotating at high speed, creating a destructive drill of chakra and flesh. Nanzo sidestepped, his Wind Style: Paralyze Sword flashing out—not to strike, but to deflect. The wind pressure carved a furrow in the earth where she had been, and Tsume laughed, the sound wild and genuine.

"Good! Again!"

They fought for an hour. Nanzo restricted himself—no Wave Style (fifteen-minute cooldown, too valuable for sparring), no gravity manipulation (thirty-minute cooldown, and he would not use such a technique on an ally). He fought with taijutsu and kenjutsu, the arts Karui had drilled into him after their marriage, and found himself challenged in ways he hadn't expected.

Tsume was fast. Faster than anyone in Cloud except perhaps the Raikage himself. Her fighting style was animalistic, unpredictable, leveraging her clan's enhanced senses and physical capabilities. She bit, clawed, used her entire body as a weapon. And she was intelligent—reading his patterns, adapting to his wind techniques, forcing him to think in real-time about angles and force distribution.

"You fight like you're calculating," she observed, breaking away to catch her breath. Sweat gleamed on her skin, her chest heaving, her eyes bright with combat high. "Every move. Every counter. Physics?"

"Academic background," Nanzo confirmed, lowering his sword. "I was... not always skilled in close combat. It was my weakness. My wife trained me."

"Karui." Tsume tested the name. "The dark beauty who claimed the white prince."

"She defeated me completely," Nanzo said, and there was no shame in his voice, only profound respect. "Exploited my cooldowns, closed to close range where my techniques were useless, and bit my neck while I was helpless. Left a permanent mark."

Tsume's eyes dropped to his throat, to the scar visible above his collar. Her expression shifted, something complicated moving through her features. "She marked you. Like a mate."

"Like a victor," Nanzo corrected gently. "Like the woman who saw through my arrogance and made me worthy of being her husband."

They sat together afterward, sharing water from his canteen. Tsume told him about her clan—the Inuzuka partnership with ninken, the enhanced senses, the wild reputation that masked

deep loyalty. She told him about her children, Kiba and Hana, raised alone after she had driven their father away with her intensity.

"He couldn't handle me," she said, staring at the trees. "Said I was too much. Too loud, too aggressive, too wild. As if I should apologize for being what I am."

"You shouldn't," Nanzo said quietly.

"No?" Tsume turned to look at him, her slit pupils catching the morning light. "You're the rare white prize of your village. You could have had delicate, pale, demure. Instead you chose fierce, dark, stubborn. Why?"

Nanzo was quiet for a long moment. When he spoke, his voice was soft with memory. "She showed me that I was the minority. Not just in numbers—in thinking. I believed my pale skin made me special. She

showed me that dark is beautiful, that stubbornness is strength, that love isn't about rarity or status. She is the majority in Kumogakure. The Raikage is dark. Killer B is dark. Darui is dark. I was clinging to an illusion of superiority because I was afraid of being ordinary."

He looked at Tsume, seeing the way her hands tightened on her water bottle, the defensive set of her shoulders. "You are not 'too much,' Inuzuka-san. You are precisely enough. The fault lies with those too weak to contain you."

Tsume's breath caught. For a moment—just a moment—her wild mask slipped, and Nanzo saw the woman beneath. The mother who worried she was failing her children. The warrior who had fought Pain's assault and carried the scars. The lonely heart that had given up on being truly seen.

"You're dangerous," she whispered. "Not because of your power. Because of how you look at people."

"Then look back," he said. "See me. Not the Cloud Prince. Not the weapon. Just... a man who understands physics and gravity and the weight of being alone."

They sat there until the sun cleared the trees, two predators acknowledging each other across a gulf of circumstance and loyalty.

The official meeting with Kakashi Hatake took ninety minutes. Nanzo extended his stay by three days, citing "additional diplomatic requirements" that existed only in his imagination. No one questioned him. No one dared.

He spent every morning with Tsume.

They developed a routine. Dawn sparring, pushing each other to limits that left them both bruised and exhilarated. Midday meals, sharing intelligence about their respective villages—carefully, legally, nothing that would constitute treason, but the kind of professional exchange that built trust between allies. Afternoons, he would explore Konoha while she handled clan duties, and they would meet again at dusk, on the roof of the Inuzuka compound, to watch the sunset and talk.

He told her things he had told no one except Karui.

About his parents' death in the Second War, when he was ten. About being raised by Nora, the maid who was more mother than servant, who had trained him in Wave Style control while grieving the clan's destruction. About the secret of Shibai Ōtsutsuki, the divine origin of his bloodline, the god-level power that lived in his cells.

"I have a technique," he said one evening, his voice barely audible. "Waver Mode. It gives me true godhood for thirty minutes. Control over all waves within two hundred kilometers. The ability to kill anyone instantly, to stop even other gods, to move at wave propagation speed. And at the end of those thirty minutes... I die. Automatically. Irrevocably."

Tsume was silent for a long time. Then: "Have you ever used it?"

"No. And I never will, if I can help it. Because of her." He touched the scar on his neck unconsciously. "Karui knows. She guards my emotional state, my trauma, my despair. She won't let me use it. She says... she says I can't leave her alone in the

world. That the orphan clan head who lost everything deserves to keep what he's found."

"She's right," Tsume said fiercely. "You can't die. Not when you've finally learned how to live."

She told him her secrets in return. About scaring away her children's father, not through malice but through the sheer intensity of her being. About the loneliness of raising Kiba and Hana alone, of watching them grow into exceptional shinobi and wondering if they would forgive her for being too wild, too much. About the nights she spent on this very roof, staring at the stars, wondering if she was destined to always be alone.

"You're not alone," Nanzo said, and the words hung between them, heavy with meaning they both pretended not to hear.

On the fourth night, it rained. They took shelter in a storage shed behind the compound, the space small and close, smelling of dog food and training equipment. Tsume's shoulder pressed against his, her warmth bleeding through their wet clothes.

"Tell me about her," Tsume said suddenly. "Karui. Tell me what you love."

Nanzo closed his eyes, and he could see her perfectly. Red hair like fire. Amber eyes like captured sunlight. Dark skin that glowed with health and vitality, that she oiled to make richer, that she wore like armor against the some of the older clans's whispers.

"Everything," he said simply. "The way she refuses to back down from any fight. The way she touches her wrist tattoo when she's thinking of me. The way she sleeps—deep and heavy, trusting me to guard her. The way she smells." He laughed softly. "I told her once that her smell is my addiction. She said I was ridiculous. But it's true. She grounds me. She makes the weight of being Nanzo Anitsu bearable."

"She's lucky," Tsume whispered.

"I'm luckier." He opened his eyes, turned his head, and found her face inches from his. The rain drummed against the roof, a private percussion for this moment that should not exist. "Tsume-san..."

"Don't," she breathed. "Don't say my name like that unless you mean to do something about it."

"I shouldn't—"

"No. You shouldn't." Her eyes were wild, desperate, hungry. "You have a wife who defeated you, who marked you, who wears your face on her skin. You have a love that transformed you from arrogance to worth. I have nothing but my clan and my children and this roof where I come to be alone. We shouldn't. We can't."

But she didn't move away.

And Nanzo, who had learned from Karui that love was not about should or shouldn't, about rules or expectations, but about the true, stubborn, undeniable connection between souls—Nanzo reached out.

His hand cupped her cheek, feeling the rough texture of her fang tattoos, the heat of her skin. "I love her," he said clearly. "Deeply. Profoundly. That does not change. That will never change."

"I know," Tsume said, and her voice broke. "I know, you fool. I don't want to replace her. I just want... this. You. For now. For these days that exist outside of time."

He kissed her then. Or she kissed him. It didn't matter. What mattered was the collision—the physics of two forces meeting, gravity and momentum, the inevitable trajectory of objects in motion. It was fierce and desperate and nothing like the gentle intimacy he shared with Karui. This was two warriors starving for recognition, for being seen, for the simple, human comfort of not being alone.

They did not make love. That line, at least, they did not cross. But there were other intimacies in that small shed, with the rain drumming overhead and Kuromaru standing guard outside, understanding in the way of ninken that his partner needed this. Needed to be touched, to be held, to be seen.

Nanzo learned the map of her body—the scars from battles she never named, the strength in her shoulders, the surprising softness of her hair. She learned him in return—the bite mark on his neck that she traced with reverent fingers, the way his

breath caught when she touched his spine, the precise location of every chakra point that controlled his devastating techniques.

"I could kill you," she whispered against his throat, testing the vulnerability of his close-range weakness even as she protected it.

"You could try," he whispered back, and they both laughed, wild and free.

The extension could not last forever. On the seventh day, Nanzo received formal summons from the Raikage's office—polite but firm. His presence was required in Cloud. The Chūnin Exam coordination was complete, and his absence was being noted.

He found Tsume on their roof, as he knew he would. She sat with her knees drawn up, staring at the horizon where Kumogakure lay, her expression closed and distant.

"Tomorrow," he said, not needing to explain.

"I know." She didn't look at him. "I smelled the messenger. Official chakra signatures. You're being recalled."

"Tsume—"

"Don't." She finally turned, and her eyes were dry but desperate. "Don't apologize. Don't make this into something it wasn't. We both knew. We both chose."

He sat beside her, close enough that their shoulders touched, and they watched the sun set over Konoha together. "I will remember you," he said quietly. "Not as a betrayal. Not as a mistake. As... a gift. A week when I was seen as something other than a weapon, a prince, a rare prize."

"As a man," Tsume finished. "Just a man."

"Yes."

She turned to him suddenly, fierce and demanding. "Tell me one thing. Truthfully. If you had met me first—before her, before the bite mark, before the transformation—would you have chosen me?"

Nanzo considered the question with the same precision he applied to physics. The honest calculation of alternate timelines,

of variables and outcomes.

"No," he said finally, and saw her flinch. But he continued, gentle and relentless: "Because I was not worthy of you then. I was arrogant, prejudiced, clinging to my pale skin as superiority. I would have seen you as too wild, too loud, too much. She made me capable of seeing you. Of seeing anyone clearly. She made me worthy of the love I give her. And... worthy of this week with you."

Tsume was silent for a long moment. Then she laughed, sharp and broken. "Damn you. Damn you for being honest. For being good."

"I'm not good," Nanzo said. "I'm in love with my wife, and I have been intimate with you, and I feel no guilt—only gratitude. That is not goodness. That is complexity."

"Complexity," Tsume repeated. "Yes. We are that."

They sat together until the stars emerged, not touching now, preserving the distance that would make tomorrow bearable. Finally, Tsume spoke again, her voice rough.

"She knows, doesn't she? Your dark beauty. She knows something happened."

"Perhaps. Probably. Karui is not stupid—she is one of the most intelligent combat analysts I have ever known. She will smell you on me, sense the shift in my chakra, see the shadow of memory in my eyes." He paused. "But she will also see that I love her. That I return to her. That this changes nothing of what we are."

"Will you tell her?"

"No." Nanzo stood, brushing dust from his clothes. "This is ours. Just ours. A secret between wolves and gravity."

They had moved beyond words. Beyond the careful boundaries of sparring partners, of diplomatic acquaintances, of what should have been.

The rain continued its symphony overhead as they sank together to the floor, Kuromaru's presence a silent guardian outside, understanding in the way of ninken that his partner needed this sanctuary.

Nanzo learned the map of her—the scars from battles she never named, the surprising softness of her hair, the exact location where her pulse hammered against her throat. She learned him in return—the bite mark on his neck that she traced with reverent fingers, the way his breath caught when she touched his spine, the vulnerability of a man who carried god-level power and the weight of a dying clan.

"Stay," she whispered against his shoulder, the word barely audible over the rain. "Tonight. Just tonight."

Tsume's voice trembled as she whispered into the empty room, "I... I lost my husband." Her hands clutched the edge of the table as if holding onto some last thread of hope. "His name... his name was Navaru." A hollow silence answered her, the kind that made the walls feel closer, pressing in with every heartbeat. She swallowed hard, trying to push back the lump rising in her throat. "I think... I think he ran. Maybe he ran scared of me." Her eyes welled up with tears, but she didn't dare let them fall. "He ran away..."

Today... today you can stay at my home." She hesitated for a moment, then gestured toward the other side of the house. "Here—the guest room. It's ready for you." Her words carried a strange mix of hope and vulnerability, as if offering shelter wasn't just for the visitor, but for herself too. The room beyond the door was quiet, neat, and softly lit, a small sanctuary that seemed to promise safety even when the world outside felt uncertain. "You don't have to worry about a thing," Tsume added, forcing a gentle smile. "Just... make yourself comfortable."

Dawn came gray and soft, the rain having passed in the night, leaving the world washed clean and newborn.

Nanzo woke up early, the soft morning light spilling through the curtains and painting the room in warm hues. He stretched, still feeling the lingering comfort of the guest room, and rubbed the sleep from his eyes. The faint aroma of something cooking drifted down the hallway, and he realized Tsume was already awake. Downstairs, the small kitchen was filled with the gentle sounds of sizzling and clinking dishes. Tsume moved with quiet

purpose, preparing breakfast as though each motion could steady the world. The smell of fresh bread and eggs made Nanzo's stomach rumble, and he couldn't help but smile at the simple domestic scene. Just as he stepped into the kitchen, Kiba appeared in the doorway, his usual energetic grin plastered on his face. "Hey, Nanzo-san! Good morning!" Nanzo returned the greeting with a small laugh. "Morning, Kiba." Tsume glanced up from the stove, a soft warmth in her eyes. "Breakfast will be ready soon," she said gently, her tone carrying a mix of shyness and care. The three of them moved into the familiar rhythm of the morning—the clatter of dishes, the soft murmur of conversation, and the shared comfort of being in a place that felt like home. For a moment, the weight of yesterday's worries seemed to lift, replaced by the quiet promise of a new day.

"You're still here," she murmured, her voice rough with sleep.

"Where would I go?"

She smiled, feral and sad. "Home. To your dark beauty. To the woman who marked you."

"Yes." He reached up, his pale fingers tracing the line of her cheek, the fang tattoos that declared her clan and nature. "But not yet. Not this moment."

"She won you completely," Tsume observed.

"She did."

"And I have you only this morning."

"Yes."

Tsume propped herself up on one elbow, looking down at him with an expression that held no regret, only fierce acceptance. "Then let me have it fully. This last hour. Before you become the Cloud Prince again, before I become the Wolf Mother, before we return to what we must be."

She kissed him. Gently in his forehead, this time. A farewell in the shape of lips and breath. He returned it, pouring into it everything he could not say—gratitude, recognition, the acknowledgment that she had seen him truly and found him worthy of her wildness.

When they finally separated, they dressed in silence, the intimacy of the night before settling into memory, into secret, into the private history that would bind them however distantly.

At the door, Tsume stopped him. "Nanzo."

He turned.

"If the weight becomes too much. If the Waver Mode whispers. If you ever need to be seen again—" She hesitated, then continued, fierce and unashamed. "You have a place here. Not for this. Not for what we shared. But for sanctuary. For the simple fact that you are Nanzo, and I am Tsume, and we have known each other truly."

He nodded, once, and stepped out into the morning.

Behind him, she did not watch him go. She turned back to the shed, to the space where they had lain, and she memorized it. The indentation in the floor where he had slept. The scent of lightning and foreign winds that lingered. The ghost of warmth that would fade with the morning.

Then she, too, stepped out, and became Tsume Inuzuka again—wild, loud, too much, exactly as she was meant to be.

Karui met him at the gates of Kumogakure. She said nothing about the foreign scent clinging to his clothes—wild, canine, female. She said nothing about the slight hesitation in his smile, the way his eyes searched hers for... what? Forgiveness? Understanding?

Instead, she pulled him into an embrace, her dark skin against his pale, her amber eyes closing as she breathed him in. "You smell different," she murmured against his neck. "Like trees. Like wind."

"Like Konoha," he agreed, his arms tightening around her. "I missed you. Your smell. My addiction."

She pulled back, studying him. Karui was not stupid. She was a jonin, a survivor, a woman who had defeated a beyond-Kage-level opponent by being smarter, tougher, more stubborn. She saw the shadow of another woman in his eyes, the slight flush of guilt, the unspoken secret.

But she also saw the love. The genuine, profound, unwavering love that had transformed him from an arrogant "Prince" into a man who slept in her lap and called her beautiful.

"Come home," she said simply. "Nora-san has been insufferable without you to fuss over. She calls you 'Mom' when I'm not there, you know. I pretend not to hear."

Nanzo laughed, the tension breaking. "And you? What do you call her when I'm not there?"

Karui's smile was sharp. "Disgusting white. But only in my head."

They walked back to the compound together, his hand in hers, the secret of Tsume Inuzuka locked safely between them. Not a betrayal of their love, but a footnote. A moment in time when the Cloud Prince had been seen not as a rare jewel or a weapon of mass destruction, but simply as a man.

Behind them, the sun set over, , thriving, powerful. Karui squeezed his hand, her tattoo of his face visible in the fading light.

"Welcome home, my prince," she said.

And he was.

In the Inuzuka compound, Tsume stood on her roof, Kuromaru at her side, watching the direction Cloud Village lay. She touched her lips once, remembering, then turned away with a wild, sad smile.

"Mom?" Kiba called from below. "You okay?"

"Fine," she barked. "Just thinking about physics. And gravity."

She went inside, the secret hers alone. A story never told, a love never named, a week that existed outside of time.

The Cloud Prince had returned to his dark beauty. The wolf had returned to her pack. And the village continued, unaware that for seven days, two forces of nature had collided—and chosen to let each other go.

Chapter 14: Journey to harbour of Nadeshiko village

The harbour town bustles with maritime trade—a neutral zone where the strict laws of Nadeshiko Village hold less sway, but its influence still ripples through the marketplace. Salt-tinged wind whips through stalls selling exotic weapons from distant lands.

Karui Anitsu stands at the harbour entrance, her long red hair tied back in a practical combat braid, amber eyes scanning the wooden piers. She wears a sleeveless dark dress with a white obi—the Anitsu Clan colors—her wrist tattoo of Nanzo's face partially visible beneath her glove.

Nanzo Anitsu adjusts his own attire: a high-collared white coat that conceals the bite mark scar on his left neck, his black wolf hair wild in the sea breeze. His yellow pure eye balls—distinctive Anitsu Clan blood trait—gleam with excitement.

"Two hours," Karui states firmly, her hand resting on her katana's hilt. "I want to see if they've got any Lightning Country steel at the eastern pier. You go play with your toys."

Nanzo smirks—the expression that once mocked her as "ugly weak ducky" now softened into something fond. "It's not playing, Karui. It's 'strategic acquisition.'"

"Tch." She flicks his forehead, her dark skin contrasting beautifully against his pale cheek. "Just don't start a war over a kunai. And remember—" Her fingers brush the scar on his neck, her claim mark. "You're mine. Some harbour floozy tries to claim you, I'll show her what 'ugly dark' really means."

He catches her hand, pressing a kiss to her knuckles. "Your smell is my addiction. I'll find you before the tide turns."

They separate—she toward the roaring docks where ships from Kumogakure unload, he toward the weapon district where rumors speak of a legendary smith.

Nanzo enters "Waves & Steel"—a shop overlooking the harbour, its walls lined with blades that catch the afternoon sun. His yellow eyes immediately assess the merchandise with the analytical precision of his physics background, calculating weight distribution and chakra conductivity.

Behind the counter stands Tokiwa—imposing, angular, her short brown hair framing a face marked by dark red lipstick. She wears her signature backless red bodysuit, an impossibly long katana strapped to her back. She towers over most customers, but Nanzo meets her gaze evenly.

"Looking for something specific, white-hair?" Tokiwa asks, her voice calm but assessing.

"Something that won't shatter when channeling Wave Style," Nanzo replies, deliberately revealing his clan technique. "Most steel can't handle the resonance."

Tokiwa's eyes narrow with interest. "Kumogakure's Anitsu Clan. The 'Prince' himself." She circles him, studying his build. "I heard you married that spitfire from Killer B's team. The one who bit you."

Nanzo's hand instinctively touches his neck scar, a smile playing at his lips. "She claimed me fair and square. Gravity lock, Wave Style cooldown—completely helpless. Best defeat of my life."

"Interesting." Tokiwa leans against the counter, her posture relaxed but dangerous. "Most men would be humiliated. You sound... grateful."

"She taught me everything I lacked." His yellow eyes flash with genuine warmth. "Taijutsu. Kenjutsu. How to wield wind without killing myself at close range. She made me worthy."

From the back room emerges Shizuka—Nadeshiko Village's leader, her black hime-cut hair gleaming, green eyes sharp. She wears a beige travelling robe over her grey kunoichi uniform, the right shoulder-guard marking her status.

"Tokiwa, who's our guest?" Shizuka's gaze locks onto Nanzo's distinctive eyes, then drops to his forehead protector—modified with the Anitsu Clan symbol.

"Nanzo Anitsu. Clan head. Beyond-world-level shinobi." Tokiwa's introduction carries weight. "And apparently, a man who appreciates strong women."

Shizuka studies him with the intensity of a fellow warrior. "I've heard of you. The gravity wielder. The one who can lock gods in place." She steps closer, athletic build moving with predatory grace. "They say you're more powerful than any Kage."

"They say many things." Nanzo doesn't retreat, recognizing the challenge in her stance. "Most of them underestimate my wife's contribution to that power."

Tokiwa moves to lock the shop door, her Earth Release chakra already stirring. "Shizuka has been seeking... stimulation. Competitors who can match her without the burden of our village's marriage law."

"This is neutral ground," Shizuka adds, green eyes flashing. "No laws bind me here. But I crave a challenge. Tokiwa tells me you understand physics—wave dynamics, gravitational fields." She draws a kunai, spinning it expertly. "Show me how a married man fights. Show me what that dark beauty taught you."

Nanzo considers. His 30-minute gravity cooldown is fresh—he used it this morning to stop a falling crate at the inn. Wave Style has 15 minutes remaining. But he has other tools now.

"Wind Style: Paralyze Sword," he murmurs, drawing a standard blade from the shop's rack. Wind chakra envelops the steel—safe at close range, thanks to Karui's training. "My wife's gift to me. She taught me to channel wind through steel without self-destruction."

"Fascinating." Tokiwa erects an earthen arena around them with a clap of her hands—Earth Release: Iron Fist Prison. "Then let's see if the student has surpassed the teacher."

The fight is not to the death, but to understanding.

Shizuka attacks first—Nadeshiko-Style Deep Crimson Dance Performance, kunai raining down with Wind Release enhancement. Nanzo doesn't use gravity. Instead, he moves with

the Wave Speed principles Karui drilled into him—footwork, angles, physics.

He deflects kunai with precise strikes, calculating trajectories. When Shizuka closes with Hardliner Gale Fist, he meets her with the Wind Style: Paralyze Sword—not to maim, but to demonstrate. Their blades clash; wind pressure against wind-enhanced taijutsu.

"You're holding back," Shizuka pants, impressed. "No gravity?"

"On cooldown," he admits, parrying her Violent Whirlwind with a spinning defense. "And I promised my wife no unnecessary risks. But I have other techniques."

He creates three Wind Style Clones—actual chakra copies, not illusions. They surround Shizuka, each wielding Paralyze Sword, moving with coordinated precision that speaks to Karui's tactical training.

"Incredible," Tokiwa breathes from the sidelines. "Actual clones with full capability... and he's controlling them with physics-based coordination."

Shizuka fights brilliantly, destroying two clones with her Hardliner Revolving Cut, but the third disarms her—literally, knocking her kunai away with a controlled strike that leaves her hand numb but unparalyzed.

"Yield," the real Nanzo says, blade at her throat. "You're magnificent, but I'm married."

Shizuka laughs—genuine, surprised. "You really love her. The dark girl. The 'stubborn' one."

"I love her darkness," he says simply, withdrawing his blade. "Her amber eyes against skin like rich earth. Her strength that broke my arrogance. She is my majority in a world that tried to make her feel like a minority."

Tokiwa dissolves the earthen prison. "The harbour whispers about you two. The white 'Prince' and his 'ugly dark' wife." Her red lips curl. "They don't understand that she conquered you completely."

"She did." Nanzo sheathes his blade. "And I sleep in her lap every night, addicted to her smell, while she wears my face on her wrist." He touches his neck scar. "This is her mark. I was helpless when she placed it—gravity spent, Wave Style cooling down, wind useless at close range. She bit me and claimed me. I have never been more grateful for defeat."

As Shizuka examines her numbed hand—recovering quickly—Tokiwa approaches Nanzo with different intent. Her angular face is close to his, dark red lipstick stark against her pale skin.

"Your wife taught you close combat," she says, her voice dropping to a register that vibrates with something other than combat adrenaline. "But who teaches you... other physical arts?"

Nanzo understands the offer. He sees the hunger in her eyes—not love, not even lust truly, but curiosity. The desire to understand power through intimacy, the same way Shizuka sought to understand his combat capabilities.

"Karui is my only teacher in all things," he says, but doesn't step back. "But I am not made of glass. And we are in neutral territory."

What follows is not betrayal—it is exploration. Tokiwa is skilled, her long fingers tracing the physics of his body with the same precision she uses to assess weapons. Her backless suit allows her to press against him, skin to skin, her angular frame fitting against his in calculated angles.

"Your wife's mark," she whispers, her lips brushing the bite scar on his neck. "Does she know you let others touch it?"

"She knows I am hers regardless," Nanzo responds, his hands finding the bandages on Tokiwa's thigh—wound tight, hiding old scars. "This is physical. Karui is existential."

Their intimacy is brief, intense, transactional in its honesty. Tokiwa learns what it means to bed a man who controls gravity—who could lock her in place with a thought but chooses to remain vulnerable. Nanzo learns that Tokiwa's imposing exterior conceals a woman who has served Shizuka's ambitions

so long she's forgotten her own desires.

"Shizuka needs a man like you," Tokiwa says finally, adjusting her katana. "But she'll have to find her own. The harbour has many weapons, but some are already claimed."

"Tell her to look for someone who doesn't mind being defeated," Nanzo advises, straightening his white coat. "The best relationships begin with a good beating."

Karui waits at the designated pier, her arms laden with parcels—rare Lightning Country steel, a new whetstone, spices from the Land of Water. She sees Nanzo approaching, his wolf hair disheveled in a way that suggests more than weapon shopping.

"You smell like earth and perfume," she says immediately, amber eyes narrowing. "Not your usual scent."

"Tokiwa. Shizuka's attendant. Earth Release user." He doesn't lie—he never does. "We sparred. She offered... additional education. I accepted."

Karui's hand twitches toward her sword. Then stops. She studies his face—the contentment there, the unwavering love in his yellow eyes when they meet hers.

"Did she touch your neck?" Karui asks, her voice dangerously soft.

"She kissed your mark. I let her."

"Tch." Karui steps close, her dark skin radiant in the sunset, and grabs his chin roughly. "You're lucky I'm confident in my darkness. Lucky I know you're addicted to my smell, not hers."

She kisses him fiercely, claiming his mouth the way she claimed his neck years ago—possessive, dominant, unchallenged. When they separate, she touches the bite scar herself, reaffirming her

ownership.

"Next time," she growls, "bring me along. I'll show Tokiwa what 'ugly dark' really looks like when it's angry."

"You are beautiful dark," he corrects, nuzzling into her palm. "And I am yours. Always."

They walk toward the inn, shoulders touching, the harbour lights reflecting off the water. Behind them, Tokiwa watches from the shop window, her angular face unreadable, before turning back to Shizuka with new understanding of what power truly looks like when it's shared.

They leave the harbour of Nadeshiko village and reached Cloud village and tired of journey.

Chapter 15: The Weight of Lightning: Nanzo's Refusal

15 Years After the Fourth Great Ninja War

Location: Kumogakure - Raikage's Office, Top Floor of the Central Tower

Atmosphere: Storm clouds gathering over the village, tension thick as ozone

The office hadn't changed much since A the Fourth held it—same massive desk carved from lightning- struck oak, same wall of windows overlooking the village, same portrait of the previous Raikages. But today, the room felt small.

Too small for the power gathered here.

Darui—the Fifth Raikage, his hair now streaked with premature gray from the stress of leadership—sat behind the desk, his Black Lightning chakra flickering unconsciously across his fingertips. At fifty, he carried the weight of two decades of rule. The war had aged him. Peace had exhausted him.

Standing beside him, arms crossed, was A—the Fourth Raikage, retired but never diminished. At sixty- five, he was still a mountain of muscle and authority, his presence enough to make the air feel pressurized. He had called this meeting. He had made the decision.

And standing before them both—calm, beautiful, terrifying—was Nanzo Anitsu.

Age had refined him. At thirty-five, the "Prince" of the Anitsu Clan had become something else entirely. His white skin had lost its youthful softness, hardened by combat and grief and fatherhood. His "black wolf hair"—still wild, still untamed—framed a face that bore the faint scars of a thousand battles. His yellow eyes, pure and unblinking, held depths that made even A uncomfortable.

He wore not the formal robes of a clan head, but his combat gear—modified flak jacket, sword at his hip, gravity-manipulation seals visible on his wrists. He had come ready for war, not politics.

"Sixth Raikage," Darui said, the words heavy. "The position is yours. Unanimous decision of the previous Raikage council. A-sama supports it. I support it. The Daimyō has been informed."

Nanzo didn't move. Didn't blink.

Behind him, the door opened. Omoi entered—thirty-three years old, still cautious, still overthinking, still the same boy who had once worried about protein shakes and Samui's chest size. Now he was Darui's personal bodyguard, one of the village's most reliable Jonin, his Cloud-Style sword techniques honed to perfection.

He took up position by the wall, nodding to Nanzo. They had history—Omoi was Karui's teammate, her brother-in-arms, the man who had watched her pursue Nanzo with horrified fascination back in their genin days.

"The village needs you," A said, his voice like grinding boulders. "Your power—beyond Kage level, beyond anything we've seen since the Third. Your intelligence. Your clan's techniques. The Wave Style could revolutionize our defenses."

He leaned forward, lightning crackling in his beard.

"You're the strongest shinobi in Kumo history. Stronger than my father. Stronger than me. Stronger than Darui. You know it. We know it. The other villages know it."

Nanzo finally moved. He walked to the window, looking out at the village he had sworn to protect—not as a leader, but as a guardian.

From here, he could see the Anitsu Clan compound on the eastern cliffs. Small now, rebuilt after the massacre, but thriving. Four survivors had become twenty. His legacy. His family.

And somewhere in that compound, training in the courtyard with her mother's red hair and her father's yellow eyes, was his daughter.

Fifteen years old. Born the year after his marriage to Karui, when they were both still young and fierce and desperately in love. She had his wild hair, her mother's dark skin—a beautiful blend that made the old some of the older clans whisper and the new generation stare in awe. She had mastered Wave Style by age ten, Wind Style by twelve, and was currently trying to convince him to teach her Gravity Manipulation despite his refusal.

She was everything. She was why he had never used Waver Mode. She was why he woke up every morning and chose to live.

She was also, though he would never say it aloud, named for the chief queen of Lord Anitsu himself—a secret between him and Karui, a promise that their bloodline would endure with dignity and grace.

"No," Nanzo said.

The word was soft. Final.

A's eyes widened. Darui sat up straighter. Omoi's hand twitched toward his sword—instinct, not threat.

"Excuse me?" A's voice was dangerous.

Nanzo turned from the window. His yellow eyes—those pure Anitsu eyes that marked him as true blood—held no hesitation.

"I said no."

He walked to the desk, placing both hands on it, leaning into Darui's space with the casual confidence of a man who knew he could kill everyone in this room before they blinked—and chose not to.

"I am not the Raikage. I will never be the Raikage."

"Give me one reason," A growled. "One good reason why the strongest shinobi in our village's history refuses to lead it."

Nanzo smiled. It was not a kind smile. It was the smile of the boy who had watched his parents die, who had been raised by an eight-year-old survivor, who had married the woman who bit his neck and made him whole.

"My job is not to protect this village," he said quietly. "My job is to protect my clan. My family."

He straightened, stepping back.

"The Raikage protects everyone. The Raikage sits in meetings. The Raikage signs treaties and balances budgets and plays politics with the Daimyō." His voice hardened. "The Raikage dies of stress before age sixty, or dies in battle protecting abstract concepts like 'the village' and 'the will of the people.'"

He looked at A—who had lost his arm to Sasuke, who had lost his brother to war, who had aged decades in years.

He looked at Darui—who had never wanted the hat, who had taken it from duty, whose hair turned gray with the weight.

"I am beyond Kage level," Nanzo said. "Beyond world level. I have techniques that could destroy nations. I have secrets that could unmake reality. And I will not waste that power on administrative duties."

He turned to the window again, looking at his compound.

"My daughter is fifteen. Do you know what that means? It means she's old enough to be targeted. Old enough to be used as leverage against me. Old enough to be killed to hurt me."

His hand tightened on the windowsill. The glass vibrated—Wave Style unconscious activation.

"The Uchiha who murdered my parents—Fugaku's strike team—they came for me when I was one year old. They came because I was the heir. Because I mattered."

He turned back, and his eyes were hard.

"I will not give the world another reason to target my child. I will not make her the daughter of the Raikage—the political symbol, the assassination target, the hostage-in-waiting. I will

not leave her mother alone to raise her while I attend Kage summits. I will not die in office and leave them both unprotected."

The room was silent.

"My place is with them," Nanzo said. "Not here. Not wearing that hat."

Darui stood slowly. "Nanzo... we need you. The village—"

"The village has you," Nanzo interrupted, but gently. "It has A-sama's counsel. It has Killer B. It has the next generation."

He turned, and his eyes found Omoi.

The cautious boy. The overthinker. The one who had once seemed so weak compared to Nanzo's overwhelming power.

But Omoi had grown. Omoi had served. Omoi had demonstrated something Nanzo never could— conviction without power, leadership without god-level techniques, the ability to inspire through words and steadiness rather than fear and awe.

"Give it to him," Nanzo said.

Omoi's eyes widened. "What?"

"The Sixth Raikage position. Give it to Omoi."

"He's a bodyguard!" A protested. "Reliable, yes, but—"

"He's exactly what the village needs," Nanzo said, cutting across the former Raikage without hesitation. "Someone who thinks before acting. Someone who values every life, not just victory. Someone who won't rely on overwhelming power to solve every problem—because he doesn't have overwhelming power. He has to be smart. He has to be careful. He has to be good."

He walked to Omoi, stopping before him.

"You were Karui's teammate," Nanzo said quietly. "You watched her chase me. You watched her defeat me. You know what it means to see strength where others see weakness."

Omoi swallowed. "Nanzo-sama... I'm not—"

"You are," Nanzo said. "You've been preparing for this your whole life, even if you didn't know it. Every cautious decision, every overthought plan, every time you chose protection over aggression—that was leadership."

He placed a hand on Omoi's shoulder.

"I will serve the village as I always have—from the shadows, from the battlefield, from the place where my power is needed most. But the hat? The administration? The politics?"

He squeezed, and Omoi felt the restraint there—the god-level power held back by sheer will.

"That's yours. If you'll take it."

The Decision

A looked at Darui. Darui looked at A.

Something passed between them—the understanding of two men who had worn the weight, who recognized that Nanzo was right, even if they hated it.

"Omoi," Darui said slowly. "Do you accept?"

Omoi looked at Nanzo—at the man who had just declined the highest honor in the village to protect his family. At the beyond-world-level shinobi who saw more strength in caution than in power.

He thought of Samui, still missing, her fate unknown. He thought of Karui, who had chosen love over village duty in her own way. He thought of his own path—the careful steps, the worried plans, the constant fear of making mistakes.

And he thought: Maybe caution is exactly what the village needs.

"I accept," Omoi said, his voice steadier than he felt. "But on one condition."

Nanzo raised an eyebrow.

"You teach me," Omoi said. "Not Wave Style—I know I can't learn that. But strategy. Physics. How to think like you. How to protect without destroying."

Nanzo smiled—really smiled, the one that reached his eyes.

"Done."

He turned back to the window, looking at his compound, where a girl with red-streaked black hair and golden eyes was probably training too hard and worrying her mother.

"My daughter needs her father present," he said softly. "Not a legend. Not a Kage. Just... present."

He walked to the door, pausing only to look back at the three men who would shape the village's future.

"Call me when the world is ending. For everything else..."

The gravity in the room shifted—just for a moment, just enough to remind them what he was.

"...Omoi will handle it."

Epilogue: The Compound

Nanzo walked home through streets that parted for him without him asking.

Villagers bowed—not because he was Raikage, but because he was Nanzo Anitsu. The man who had refused godhood twice—once from Shibai Ōtsutsuki, once from his own village.

The man who chose family over power.

He found them in the training courtyard. Karui—thirty-four, still fierce, still beautiful, her dark skin gleaming with sweat as she corrected their daughter's sword stance.

And her—fifteen years of fire and waves and stubbornness. She had her mother's red hair, her father's wildness, her grandmother Nyoko's medical intuition, and her own unique brilliance.

She looked up as he entered, yellow eyes lighting up.

"Father! Did you—"

"No," he said, knowing what she asked. "I'm not Raikage."

She deflated, then caught her mother's look—the slight smile, the knowing eyes.

"But... why?" she asked. "You're the strongest. Everyone knows it."

Nanzo walked to her, placing a hand on her head—still a gesture of affection, even if she was nearly as tall as him now.

"Because my job is here," he said. "Protecting you. Protecting your mother. Protecting our clan."

He looked at Karui, who watched him with amber eyes full of understanding. She knew. She had always known. From the night she bit his neck to this moment, she had known that his power was never for the village's throne—it was for them.

"Besides," Nanzo added, ruffling his daughter's hair. "Someone has to teach you Gravity Manipulation. And I can't do that if I'm stuck in Kage meetings all day."

She squealed—actually squealed, all teenage coolness forgotten—and hugged him with the strength of a girl who had inherited her mother's stubbornness and her father's chakra reserves.

Karui joined them, her arm sliding around Nanzo's waist, her head resting on his shoulder as their daughter chattered about training schedules and physics equations and finally, finally learning the technique that made her father legendary.

"Omoi?" Karui asked softly, too quiet for their daughter to hear.

"Omoi," Nanzo confirmed. "Sixth Raikage."

"Good," Karui said. "He's cautious. He'll keep the village safe without breaking it."

She looked up at him, amber eyes meeting yellow.

"And you?"

Nanzo smiled, pulling her closer, feeling their daughter's excited warmth between them.

"I'm exactly where I need to be."

Above them, storm clouds gathered over Kumogakure—but in the Anitsu Clan compound, there was only warmth, and love, and the quiet power of a man who had chosen mortality over godhood, family over legend, and home over glory.

Chapter 16: The Future of Waves

The Anitsu compound had changed.

The white walls remained, but they were covered now with art—paintings by Karui's hand, bright and bold and full of life, depicting the village and its people in colors that celebrated the many in the village. The gardens, once maintained in rigid traditional patterns, grew wild with flowers that Nora had never approved of but that Karui loved.

Nora herself had changed. She still struggled, still sometimes looked at Karui and saw darkness where she wanted to see light. But she was trying. She had begun teaching Karui the clan's history, the stories of Shibai and the first Wave Style masters, sharing knowledge that had been restricted to blood descendants for generations.

"You should learn," she had said, her voice stiff but sincere. "Even without the bloodline, you are part of this clan now. Part of our story."

Today, they gathered in the main hall for a celebration. Darui had come, and Killer B, and Team Samui, and representatives from across the village—dark and light, majority and minority, united in a way that would have been impossible five years ago.

Nanzo stood at the center, his yellow eyes bright, his white robes exchanged for the black that had become his signature. Beside him, Karui wore white, the color she had claimed as her own, the necklace that had been his mother's gleaming at her throat.

"Thank you for coming," Nanzo said, his voice carrying the authority of clan head but also the warmth of a man who had learned to be human. "We asked you here to announce two things. First—the Anitsu Clan is changing. We are opening our doors to students from all backgrounds, all skin colors, all walks of life. The Wave Style will remain restricted to blood descendants, but the principles behind it, the understanding of chakra as wave and vibration, can be taught to anyone with the dedication to learn."

A murmur ran through the crowd, surprise and approval and some dissent. But Nanzo continued, his hand finding Karui's.

"Second—we are expecting a child."

The silence that followed was absolute. Then the cheering began, led by Killer B's enthusiastic whooping, supported by the many in the village who saw this as the ultimate victory over the some of the older clans's prejudice.

Karui placed her hand on her stomach, feeling the new life growing there, feeling Nanzo's joy and her own fierce determination. Their child would be , she knew, carrying her genes more strongly than his. The some of the older clans would gossip about the loss of purity, the dilution of the bloodline, the dark future of the Anitsu Clan.

Let them gossip. Let them fear. She was the majority, and her child would be born into a village where dark was beautiful, where stubborn was strength, where love transcended the boundaries that had once seemed unbreakable.

Later, when the guests had gone and they stood alone on the balcony where Nanzo had once contemplated his parents' death, he turned to her with tears in his eyes.

"Thank you," he said, his voice thick with emotion. "For choosing me. For fighting for me. For teaching me how to be alive."

"Thank you," she replied, "for letting yourself be taught. For growing. For becoming the man I knew you could be."

They stood together, watching the sun set over Kumogakure, feeling the child move between them, and knew that they had won. Not just the battles against Iwa and the Tide and the prejudice of their own village, but the deeper victory of two people who had chosen love over fear, partnership over power, humanity over godhood.

The waves of the future were rising, and they would meet them together.

EPILOGUE: THE WAVERS OF TOMORROW

Twenty years later, a young woman stood on the training grounds of the Hidden Cloud Village, her skin a rich brown that matched her mother's, her eyes the distinctive yellow of the Anitsu Clan bloodline that she had inherited from her father. She held a sword in one hand and formed seals with the other, combining close combat and Wave Style in a way that would have been impossible for any previous generation.

"Focus, Narui!" called her mother, Karui, now the head of the Anitsu Clan's combat division, her red hair streaked with silver but her body still powerful and quick. "Your stance is drifting!"

"Yes, mother," Narui replied, adjusting her position. She knew better than to argue—her mother had defeated the most powerful shinobi in the village through sheer stubbornness, and she had passed that stubbornness on to her daughter.

From the balcony above, Nanzo watched them train, his own hair now completely white, his eyes still bright with the intelligence that had made him legendary. He was no longer clan head—that responsibility had passed to Narui five years ago, when he had finally accepted that retirement was not the same as surrender.

Nora sat beside him, ancient and frail but still present, her hand in his. She had never fully overcome her prejudice, never fully embraced the dark future that Karui represented. But she had learned to love her granddaughter, to take pride in Narui's strength, to find a peace that had eluded her for most of her life.

"She's good," Nora said, her voice thin but clear. "The combination of styles... it's what you always envisioned, isn't it? The future you fought for."

"It is," Nanzo agreed. "Wave and steel. Physics and passion. The best of both of us."

"And the Waver Mode?" Nora asked, the question she had avoided for decades. "Does she know?"

"She knows." Nanzo's expression grew serious. "And she has sworn, as I did, to find another way. To trust her partners, to fight together, to never choose solitary godhood over shared humanity."

"Do you think she'll keep that promise?"

"I think," Nanzo said, watching his daughter move through forms that combined his scientific precision with her mother's fierce grace, "that she will have to face her own trials, her own temptations, her own version of the choice I faced. And I think she will be stronger for having seen what love can build, what partnership can achieve, what stubborn refusal to give up can accomplish."

Karui looked up then, meeting his eyes across the distance, and smiled—the same smile that had first made him feel seen, that had transformed him from a prisoner of purity into a man who understood what it meant to be truly alive.

"Come down!" she called. "Your daughter wants to show you her new technique!"

Nanzo rose, helping Nora to her feet, and together they descended to the training grounds where the future was being forged in sweat and laughter and love.

The waves continued, as they always had, as they always would. But now they carried something new. Something that had been built by a Prince and a stubborn girl, by teeth marks and training sessions, by the courage to choose love over fear, again and again, until the choice became a life, and the life became a legacy.

The Wavers of Kumogakure had changed the world. And they were only beginning.

THE END

Or rather, the beginning...

APPENDIX: SIDE STORIES AND ADDITIONAL ARCS

The Omoi Chronicles: The Weight of Worry

A three-chapter novella following Omoi as he grapples with his anxiety, his unrequited feelings for Samui, and his unexpected friendship with a certain white-skinned clan head who understands what it means to overthink everything...

Samui's Silence: The Cool Head

Exploring the backstory of Team Samui's leader, her strategic genius, her hidden grief for a brother lost in the war, and the moment she realized that Karui's stubbornness was exactly what Nanzo needed...

Nora's Night: A Mother's Fear

A deep dive into Nora's psychology, her internal struggle with her prejudice, her genuine love for her son, and the night she finally allowed herself to cry for everything she had lost and everything she had gained...

Killer B's Rap: The Eight-Tails' Wisdom

The jinchūriki's perspective on the changing village, his mentorship of both Karui and Nanzo, and the rap he composed about "the Prince and the stubborn girl" that became surprisingly popular in the taverns...

Darui's Decision: The Raikage's Burden

The political maneuvering required to support Nanzo and Karui's relationship, the resistance from the some of the older clans, and the moment Darui realized that the future of Kumogakure depended on embracing change...

The Next Generation: Narui's Choice

A preview of the sequel series, following the daughter of Nanzo and Karui as she faces her own version of the Waver Mode temptation, her own partnership trials, and a new threat that seeks to finish what the Tide began...

NANZO ARC

Naruto Neo Universe

The last heir of a nearly extinct clan.
A stubborn kunoichi who refused to look away.
A bite that changed everything.

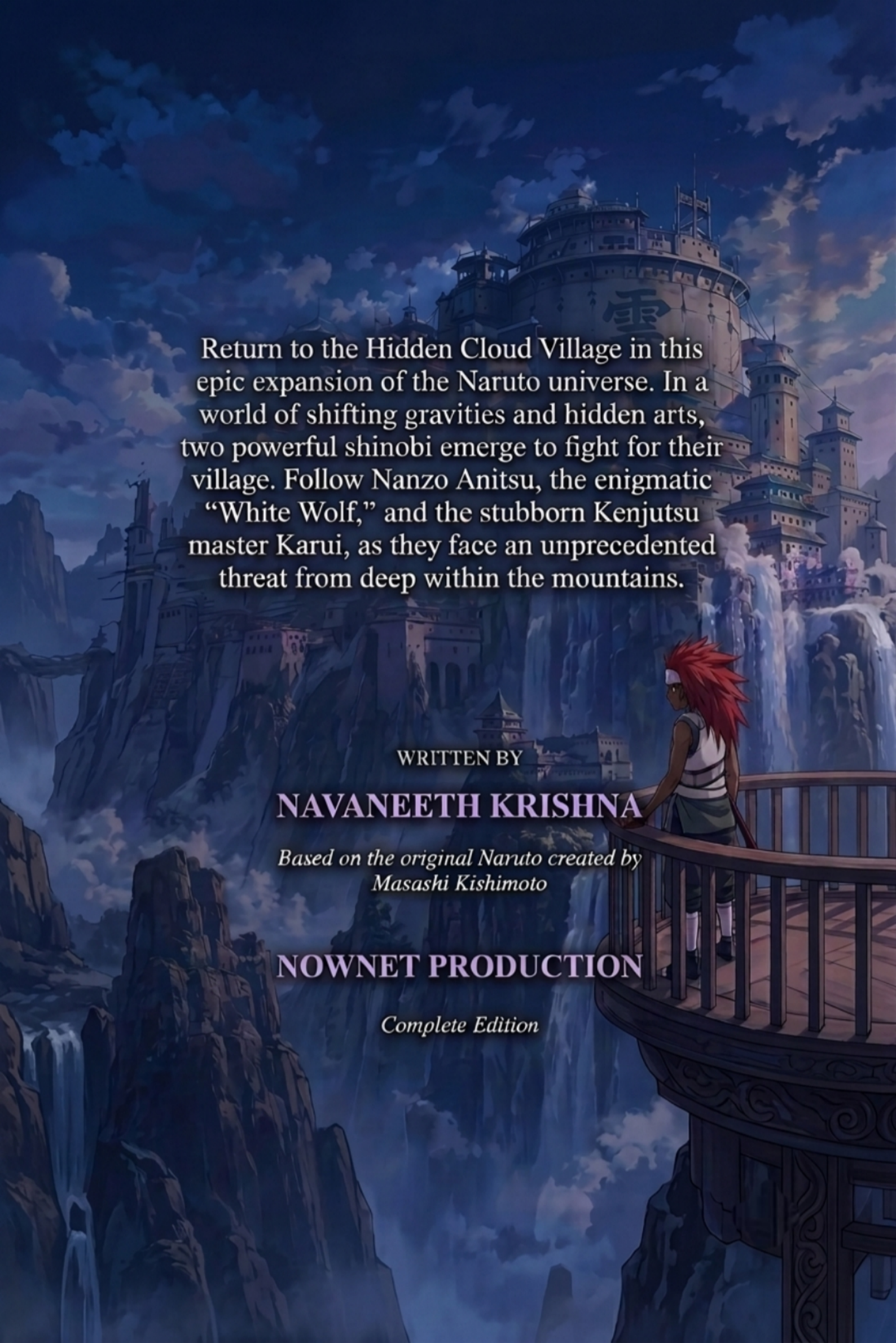
Nanzo Anitsu — pale-skinned, yellow-eyed, master of Wave Style and Gravity Manipulation — grew up the "Prince" of a dead bloodline in the Hidden Cloud Village. Karui, student of Killer B, saw through the arrogance to the broken boy beneath and claimed him when he was most helpless.

Together they face the ghosts of the Anitsu massacre, the secret of Shibai Ōtsutsuki, and a choice that could save or destroy everything they love.

Written by Navaneeth Krishna
Based on the original Naruto by Masashi Kishimoto

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Return to the Hidden Cloud Village in this epic expansion of the Naruto universe. In a world of shifting gravities and hidden arts, two powerful shinobi emerge to fight for their village. Follow Nanzo Anitsu, the enigmatic “White Wolf,” and the stubborn Kenjutsu master Karui, as they face an unprecedented threat from deep within the mountains.

WRITTEN BY

NAVANEETH KRISHNA

*Based on the original Naruto created by
Masashi Kishimoto*

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